

Spanish subject-verb agreement as cliticization: A Merge-based approach

John David Storment
Stony Brook University

Abstract: In this paper, I evaluate the claim that cliticization and “true” phi-agreement are technologically distinct from one another (Zwicky & Pullum 1983; Kramer 2014; Preminger 2014; Yuan 2021, a.o.) against the argument clitic and subject-verb inflectional paradigms from Spanish, showing that argument clitics and subject-verb agreement morphemes in this language display a striking number of formal and distributional similarities that cast doubt on the idea that these two phenomena are underlyingly distinct. Motivated by these similarities, I unify these phenomena by reducing subject-verb agreement to the technology involved in cliticization (e.g., Taraldsen 1992; 1993; Barbosa 1995; Ordóñez 1997; Ordóñez & Treviño 1999). Here, I adopt a view of clitics as functional heads that license particular features of certain arguments (Sportiche 1996), which I cast in terms of the Strong Minimalist Thesis (SMT) (Chomsky et al. 2019; Chomsky 2021; Chomsky 2024, a.o.), showing that this unified analysis does not require any computational stipulations in the narrow-syntactic component of grammar other than simplest Merge. This analysis is able to explain various clitic/agreement interaction effects in Spanish, and I additionally connect it to discussions of subject licensing and crosslinguistic variation within Romance.

Keywords: clitics, agreement, Spanish, SMT, Merge, licensing, variation

1 Introduction

I am concerned in this paper with the degree of distinction that can be drawn between cliticization and agreement morphology (e.g., Preminger 2009). Much work maintains that cliticization and agreement should be treated as both descriptively and derivationally totally distinct from one another (Preminger 2009; 2014; Nevins 2011; Kramer 2014; Anagnostopoulou 2016; Baker & Kramer 2018; Coon & Keine 2021; Yuan 2021; Burukina 2026, a.o.), while other work argues that cliticization and agreement should receive the same underlying treatment, either by way of reducing cliticization to the technology involved in agreement (Suñer 1988; Brandi & Cordin 1989; Paparounas & Salzmann 2024; see also Jambrović 2025:92 and references therein), or by way of reducing agreement to the technology involved in cliticization (Taraldsen 1992; 1993; Barbosa 1995; Ordóñez 1997; Ordóñez & Treviño 1999).

Spanish, which has a rich system of argument cliticization (1) as well as robust subject-verb agreement morphology (2) (Kayne 1989; 1991; Uriagereka 1995; Ordóñez 1997, a.o.), offers an ideal testing ground to evaluate the connection between cliticization and agreement, examining whether there is sufficient evidence in this language to claim that cliticization should be considered operationally distinct from so-called “true” agreement morphology (Preminger 2009).

- (1) (Él) *me=* ve.¹
(he) me.ACC=sees
'He sees me.'

¹ I follow standard conventions of the Leipzig Glossing Rules for examples throughout the paper. I use the symbol ‘=’ to delineate the boundary of what is traditionally considered a clitic, whereas ‘-’ is used to delineate the boundary of what is traditionally considered an agreement affix. I consider this to be a descriptive distinction of little theoretical import, as supported by the conclusions drawn in this paper.

- (2) Yo ve -o.
 I see-1SG
 ‘I see.’

Exploring the nature of these phenomena in Spanish has implications for the connection between agreement morphology and clitics in Romance more generally, and in linguistic theory as a whole.

Work supporting the view that cliticization and “true” agreement should be treated as completely derivationally distinct from one another argues that the operations involved in cliticization and “true” agreement are underlyingly technologically separate. Kramer (2014:539) summarizes this view, stating that “agreement is the realization of phi features on v , whereas clitic doubling is often analyzed as the movement of a D head in order to attach to a verb.” This line of research claims that, as a result of being underlyingly distinct, instances of cliticization and “true” phi-agreement can be differentiated from one another by their formal and distributional properties.

In this paper, I critically examine the claim that “true” phi-agreement should be treated as a distinct syntactic operation from that of cliticization. Using cases of argument cliticization and subject-verb agreement in Spanish, I show that the line between cliticization and “true” agreement is much blurrier than what has been suggested in the literature. I demonstrate this by applying tests from Preminger (2009; 2014), Nevins (2011), Kramer (2014), and others to the Spanish argument clitic and verbal inflectional paradigms, and use the results of these tests to argue that cliticization and subject-verb agreement morphology are too similar to clearly technologically distinguish from one another in this way.

I argue that the results of these tests support a view of Spanish subject-verb agreement morphology as an instance of argument clitic doubling, following Taraldsen (1992; 1993), Barbosa (1995), Ordóñez (1997), and Ordóñez & Treviño (1999). I further argue that these facts are best explained under what I call a Merge-based approach to cliticization and agreement—borrowing terminology from Collins (2024)—in which the phenomena of argument cliticization and subject-verb agreement morphology are unified under an analysis of clitics as functional heads that license particular properties (i.e., features) of thematic arguments (Sportiche 1996). This analysis places a discussion of the distinct technologies that have been claimed to underly cliticization and “true” agreement in the context of the Strong Minimalist Thesis (SMT) (Berwick & Chomsky 2016; Chomsky et al. 2019; Chomsky 2021; Chomsky et al. 2023; Chomsky 2024), critically examining the role of Agree and the technologies involved in it and ultimately arguing that Merge is sufficient as the sole syntactic operation involved in both cliticization and “true” phi-agreement. Under this approach, various interaction effects with clitics and subject-verb agreement are explained.

In Sect. 2, I apply diagnostics from the literature meant to distinguish cliticization from “true” agreement based on their formal and combinatoric properties to Spanish, highlighting the ways in which the Spanish data complicate these diagnostics. In Sect. 3, I bring up some theoretical issues regarding the supposed strict differentiation between cliticization and agreement morphology within a Minimalist syntactic framework. Sect. 4 puts forth a unified approach to cliticization and agreement, showing that the Merge-based approach effectively explains the similarities and differences between cliticization and so-called “true” agreement, as well as adequately explaining several properties of Spanish/Romance clitic constructions. In Sect. 4 I also touch on questions of subject licensing in Romance and explaining crosslinguistic variation in the SMT. Sect. 5 concludes.

2 Clitics vs agreement: Empirical qualities

Much of the recent literature on cliticization and agreement makes a clear technical distinction between these two phenomena. See the following.

- (3) ‘One [operation] is *agreement*, in which the host and the full noun phrase enter into some formal relation, as a result of which features of the full noun phrase (e.g., person, number, gender) are morphologically reflected on the host. The other operation is *clitic doubling*, which generally refers to a situation in which a phonologically small, pronoun-like morpheme is generated on the basis of the full noun phrase...and affixes to the host’ (Preminger 2009:620).
- (4) ‘Agreement is the realization of phi features on v , whereas clitic doubling is often analyzed as the movement of a D head in order to attach to a verb’ (Kramer 2014:539).
- (5) ‘While morphological agreement is the morphological spell-out of valued phi-features, we follow much previous work that takes pronominal cliticization to be an instance of long head movement of a D head, triggered by an underlying phi-Agree relationship between the probe and the goal D’ (Coon & Keine 2021:668).
- (6) ‘Verbal agreement morphology is commonly analyzed as the morphological reflex of phi-feature valuation of a probing head H^0 by a phi-bearing goal, the result of Agree. Unlike true agreement, clitic doubling involves a pronominal D^0 element cooccurring and coreferring with a DP associate’ (Yuan 2021:154).

These sources argue that, as a result of their underlying derivations being distinct, cliticization and agreement morphology can be formally differentiated from one another using specific diagnostics (see also Zwicky & Pullum (1983)). Here, I go through several of these diagnostics, showing that they do not draw a such a clear distinction between Spanish argument clitics and subject-verb agreement. These diagnostics include optionality (Sect. 2.1), morpheme stacking (Sect. 2.2), the availability of a default form (Sect. 2.3), formal resemblance to strong pronouns (Sect. 2.4), and contextual (in)variance (Sect. 2.5).

2.1 Optionality (or lack thereof)

Regarding a formal differentiation between cliticization and agreement, Kramer (2014) states the following generalizations.

- (7) *Differentiation between agreement and clitic doubling* (Kramer 2014:598)
 - a. *Agreement* = affix, obligatory, realization of valued phi-features on a functional head.
 - b. *Clitic doubling* = morphophonological clitic, optional, D that has moved to a verbal functional head.

I focus here on the claim that agreement should be obligatory, while clitic doubling should be optional. In Spanish, it is very easy to find cases of what is typically considered subject-verb agreement being optionally realized. See the following examples involving impersonal *se* clauses

(8), existentials (9), specificational copular clauses (10), dative experiencer verbs (11), certain postverbal subjects (12)-(13), and sylleptic agreement with collective nouns (14).

- (8) a. Se= censura-n los documentos. (Ormazabal & Romero 2024:445-6)
 SE= censor -3PL the documents
 b. Se= censura-Ø los documentos.
 SE= censor -3SG the documents
 ‘The documents were censored.’
- (9) a. Hub -o dos hombres en la fiesta. (Rodríguez-Mondoñedo 2008:326-7)
 have-3SG.PAST two men in the party
 b. Hub -ieron dos hombres en la fiesta.
 have-3PL.PAST two men in the party
 ‘There {was/were} two men at the party.’
- (10) a. Lo que am -o más en este mundo es los hombres guapos. (Storment 2025:4)
 it that love-1SG most in this world COP.3SG the men beautiful
 b. Lo que am -o más en este mundo son los hombres guapos.
 it that love-1SG most in this world COP.3PL the men beautiful
 ‘What I love most in this world {is/are} beautiful men.’
- (11) a. Nos= encanta-n las películas de terror. (Fernández-Serrano 2022:9)
 us.DAT=love -3PL the films of terror
 b. Nos= encanta-Ø las películas de terror.
 us.DAT=love -3SG the films of terror
 ‘We love horror movies.’
- (12) a. Ha -n venido muchas turistas este año. (Aragonese Spanish, Saura 2010:575)
 have-3PL come.PRT many tourists this year
 b. Ha -Ø venido muchas turistas este año.
 have-3SG come.PRT many tourists this year
 ‘There {have/has} come many tourists this year.’
- (13) a. Me= llam -aron mientras estaba en la playa mis primos. (Villa-García 2009:250)
 me.DAT= call -3PL.PAST while was.1SG in the beach my cousins
 b. ?Me= llam -ó mientras estaba en la playa mis primos.
 me.DAT= call -3SG.PAST while was.1SG in the beach my cousins
 ‘My cousins called me while I was at the beach.’
- (14) a. La mayoría de los chicos no asiste -n a clase. (Martínez 1999:2766)
 the majority of the boys no attend-3PL to class
 b. La mayoría de los chicos no asiste -Ø a clase.
 the majority of the boys no attend-3SG to class
 ‘The majority of the boys {do/does} not attend class.’

I include here as well instances of so-called person “unagreement” (Höhn 2016, a.m.o.) as a case of optional agreement given the precedent in the literature for discussing it as such (e.g., Villa-García 2009). I pause to clarify this point because the alternation in agreement in (15) between the

(a) form and the (b) or (c) forms is clearly associated with an alternation in meaning as well, which is not necessarily the case of the examples in (8)-(14). Nevertheless, I include the example of person unagreement as a case of agreement optionality here because it constitutes variable realization in agreement with subjects that are identical on the surface.

- (15) a. Los estudiantes tiene-n mala memoria. (Ordóñez & Treviño 1999:58)
 the students have-3PL bad memory
 b. Los estudiantes tene -mos mala memoria.
 the students have-1PL bad memory
 c. Los estudiantes tene -is mala memoria.
 the students have-2PL bad memory
 ‘The students have bad memory.’

Ordóñez & Treviño (1999) take the existence of unagreement in the (b) and (c) examples of (15) to be evidence of subject-verb agreement as cliticization, a point that I return to later. See also variable 1PL/2PL agreement with existentials *habemos/habéis* (Rodríguez-Mondoñedo 2008).

Having presented various cases of agreement being optionally realized, I turn now to instances of cliticization being obligatorily realized in Spanish. While it is true that, for the most part, verbal agreement with the structural and/or thematic subject is a relation that obligatorily obtains in Spanish (see the obvious ungrammaticality of something like **Yo quiere* ‘I want.3SG’), it would be inaccurate to characterize clitic doubling as an operation that is generally optional in Spanish. In fact, it seems to me that truly optional clitic doubling is the more restricted case in Spanish (Jaeggli 1982; Bickford 1985; Hardin 1993, a.o.).

It has been extensively documented that clitic doubling with certain overt non-pronominal direct objects is optional in varieties of Spanish that allow direct object clitic doubling (Rivas 1977; Jaeggli 1982; Bickford 1985; Suñer 1988; Hardin 1993; Bleam 2000). Indeed, this fact is mentioned by Kramer (2014:602) to argue that clitic doubling is generally optional. It should be noted, however, that some researchers have taken issue with the characterization of this kind of clitic doubling as optional (e.g., Aissen & Rivas 1975:3; Estigarribia 2006).

There is a generalization that clitic doubling is obligatory with any non-GOAL/RECIPIENT use of a dative (Bickford 1985, a.o.). These cases include dative experiencer psych-predicates (16) and beneficiary indirect objects (17), as well as phenomena that I do not show for the sake of space such as possessor raising with inalienable possession (Kayne 1975).

- (16) a. La música clásica le= gusta -Ø a Renato. (Bickford 1985:192)
 the music classic him.DAT=please-3SG to Renato
 b. *La música clásica gusta -Ø a Renato.
 the music classic please-3SG to Renato
 ‘Renato likes classical music.’
- (17) a. Mi esposa les= hace -Ø comida a muchas familias pobres. (Bickford 1985:192)
 my wife them.DAT=make-3SG food to many families poor
 b. *Mi esposa hace -Ø comida a muchas familias pobres.
 my wife make-3SG food to many families poor
 ‘My wife prepares food for many poor families.’

In all varieties of Spanish, clitic doubling is obligatory with both direct object (18) and indirect object (19) personal pronouns (Jaeggli 1982; Suñer 1988; Fernández-Soriano 1993; Estigarribia 2006; Roberts 2010; Ordóñez 2012, a.o.).

- (18) a. Las= vi a ellas. (Ordóñez 2012:489)
 them.F.ACC= see.1SG.PAST to they.F
 b. *Vi a ellas.
 see.1SG.PAST to they.F
 ‘I saw them.’
- (19) a. Les= di el libro a ellas. (Ordóñez 2012:489)
 them.DAT=give.1SG.PAST the book to they.F
 b. *Di el libro a ellas.
 give.1SG.PAST the book to they.F
 ‘I gave the book to them.’

Additionally, argument clitics must appear obligatorily when there is no coreferent argument DP that appears with it, again both for direct (20) and indirect (21) objects.

- (20) a. Lo= vi. (Ordóñez 2012:478)
 him.ACC= see.1SG.PAST
 b. *Vi.
 see.1SG.PAST
 ‘I saw him.’
- (21) a. Le= di el libro. (Ordóñez 2012:479)
 him.DAT=give.1SG.PAST the book
 b. *Di el libro.
 give.1SG.PAST the book
 ‘I gave the him book.’

Assuming a theory in which even argument clitics that do not appear with an overtly doubled nominal are coreferent with a null argument *pro* (e.g., Uriagereka 1995; Sportiche 1996; Manzini & Pescarini 2022), the clitics in the (a) examples in (20) and (21) are actually obligatorily doubled, and have the following structure, with the bracketed elements unpronounced.

- (22) a. Lo= vi [a *pro*].²
 him.ACC= see.1SG.PAST [to *pro*]
 ‘I saw him’.
 b. Le= di el libro [a *pro*].
 him.DAT=give.1SG.PAST the book [to *pro*]
 ‘I gave him the book.’

² I assume a null preposition preceding this doubled *pro* in accordance with Kayne’s Generalization (Jaeggli 1982).

(i) *Kayne’s Generalization* (Jaeggli 1982:20)
 An object NP may be doubled by a clitic only if the NP is preceded by a preposition.

Under this view, the examples in (20)-(22) are a sub-case of the examples in (18) and (19), with the major difference being that the doubled pronominal elements in (20)-(22) are not overt.

It has additionally been described that clitic doubling of direct objects is not possible in a number of situations, even in dialects of Spanish such as Rioplatense which do permit optional DO clitic doubling in certain contexts. These situations include inanimate (23) and non-specific (24) direct object DPs (Jaeggli 1982; Suñer 1988, a.o.).

- (23) *La= compra-mos (a) esa novela. (Suñer 1988:396)
 it.F.ACC=buy -1PL (to) that novel
 ‘We bought that novel.’

- (24) No (*lo=) oy -eron a ningún ladrón. (Suñer 1988:396)
 no (*him.ACC=)hear -3PL.PAST to any thief
 ‘They didn’t hear any thieves.’

Again, there certainly are instances of optional clitic doubling of non-pronominal, animate, specific direct objects in Spanish in varieties such as Rioplatense (25) (Rivas 1977; Bickford 1985; Jaeggli 1982; Suñer 1988; Hardin 1993, a.o.) and *Leísta* dialects (26) (Bleam 2000).

- (25) (La=) vi a Mafalda. (Rioplatense, Ordóñez 2012:490)
 (her.ACC=)see.1SG.PAST to Mafalda
 ‘I saw Mafalda.’

- (26) (Le=) vi a Juan. (*Leísta* dialects, Bleam 2000:116)
 (him.DAT=)see.1SG.PAST to Juan
 ‘I saw Juan.’

This situation of optional clitic doubling, however, is not typical across all varieties of Spanish. In most varieties of Spanish spoken in the world today (including what can be referred to as ‘Standard’ Spanish), clitic doubling with any non-pronominal direct object is not possible at all (e.g., Ordóñez 2012:490). Which makes dialects such as Rioplatense notable. See the following.

- (27) a. (*La=) vi a Mafalda. (Standard Spanish)
 (*her.ACC=)see.1SG.PAST to Mafalda
 b. (*Le=) vi a Juan.
 (*him.DAT=) see.1SG.PAST to Juan
 ‘I saw Mafalda/Juan.’

Thus, optional direct object clitic doubling is only possible in certain varieties of Spanish with overt, non-pronominal, animate, specific nominals. In all other cases, it is either obligatorily absent or present. Therefore, any characterization of optional clitic doubling as the default state of affairs in Spanish is inaccurate, as optionality in cliticization is only borne out under a restricted set of conditions in a restricted set of language varieties.

We can observe further cases of obligatory cliticization in Spanish in other constructions as well, a few of which I mention here. One of these is impersonal/passive/generic *se* clauses, in which the *se* clitic indexes an arbitrary or generic AGENT interpretation (Otero 1986; Armstrong

& MacDonald 2021, a.m.o.). See the following example, in which the *se* clitic is necessary to the generic—or passive (Otero 1986:87—interpretation (Otero 1986; Wolfsgruber 2021). While the absence of the *se* morpheme does not lead to ungrammaticality, it does create a necessarily referential interpretation of the AGENT.

- (28) a. Se= come -Ø las manzanas. (Otero 1986:87)
 SE= eat -3SG the apples
 b. #Come-Ø las manzanas.
 eat -3SG the apples
 ‘The apples are eaten.’

Another example of obligatory clitic doubling can be seen in causatives with pre-infinitival causee (Ordóñez & Saab 2017; Ordóñez 2024), which is perhaps another instance of a non-GOAL use of a dative, though this example stands out as the clitic is optional when the causee appears following the infinitival (which I do not show here).

- (29) a. Ayer le= hice a Juan lee -r el libro. (Ordóñez 2024:6)
 yesterday him.DAT= make.1SG.PAST to Juan read-INF the book
 b. *Ayer hice a Juan lee -r el libro.
 yesterday make.1SG.PAST to Juan read-INF the book
 ‘Yesterday I made Juan read the book.’

Thus, there is an abundance of examples of optional subject-verb agreement in Spanish, as well as an abundance of cases of obligatory clitic doubling. It should be noted explicitly that these are not cherry-picked, aberrant examples; rather, they are emblematic of certain configurations in the grammar of Spanish that naturally lead to optional subject-verb agreement and/or obligatory clitic doubling. These are by no means exhaustive lists, either, as there are situations that I have not discussed here that fit the relevant criteria.

Kramer considers the possibility of such exceptions, stating: “Most agreement is obligatory, and most clitic doubling is optional, but there are exceptions both ways. This type of evidence is not robust considered on its own, but its power lies in numbers. The more of the ‘typical doubled clitic’ characteristics that the [relevant morpheme] has, the more likely it is to be a doubled clitic (and the more difficult it is to analyze as agreement)” (2014:612-3).

Given the rigid technological distinction drawn between cliticization and agreement (i.e., head movement versus feature copying), it strikes me as unexpected that a set of tools meant to differentiate the two should allow for so many exceptions, with none of them on their own constituting robust evidence³. In one sense, the diagnostic is inconclusive for Spanish. In another sense, however, the diagnostic characterizes these morphemes in very unexpected ways.

Nevertheless, this specific diagnostic makes some interesting claims about Spanish, most importantly that almost all argument clitics in the majority of cases in most dialects of Spanish

³ We can contrast the characterization of these diagnostics by Kramer with, for instance, the tests use to diagnose A-movement versus $\bar{A}$ -movement (e.g., moving out of finite clause boundaries, weak crossover, reconstruction for binding, licensing of parasitic gaps, locality constraints, etc.) (van Urk 2017, a.o.), which, for the most part, present far fewer exceptions (though they are not without complications, of course—see, for instance, Lasnik & Stowell 1991). Certainly, it is not the case that the A/ $\bar{A}$ diagnostics themselves are defined by their ability to accommodate as many exceptions as possible.

behave like “true” phi-agreement morphemes with respect to not being optional. This fact, when taken into consideration along with the tests presented in the remainder of this section, should be taken as evidence that such rigidity in the differentiation between cliticization and agreement is not on the right track, as there is a very large overlap between the two phenomena regarding their behavior according to diagnostics that are meant to differentiate between the two.

2.2 Clitic stacking: Mesocclisis

Examining for a moment the literature on the morphophonological properties of clitics versus affixation, Zwicky & Pullum (1983) note the following:

- (30) *Criterion F* (Zwicky & Pullum 1983:504)
Clitics can attach to material already containing clitics, but affixes cannot.

Spanish presents a number of well-documented counterexamples to this claim, known as mesocclisis (Harris & Halle 2005; Kayne 2010; Arregi & Nevins 2018; a.o.), which is well-attested in colloquial language varieties.

- (31) De =me -n una chela.
give.IMP.AFF=me.DAT-3PL a beer
‘Give(PL) me a beer.’

This phenomenon has a number of interesting properties. As Kayne (2010:146) notes, mesocclisis of 3pl *-n* can be doubled, appearing on both the verb and the object clitic (32). Additionally, it can appear following a sequence of multiple clitics, as in (33) (Garza 2026).

- (32) Vénda -n =lo -n. (Kayne 2010:146)
sell.IMP.AFF-3PL=it.ACC -3PL
‘Sell(PL) it.’
- (33) Dé =me =lo -n. (Garza 2026:3)
give.IMP.AFF=me.DAT=it.ACC -3PL
‘Give(PL) it to me.’

Spanish mesocclisis has received phonological (Harris & Hale 2005), syntactic (Kayne 2010), morphological (Arregi & Nevins 2018), and computational (Garza 2026) analyses, with Kayne (2010), Arregi & Nevins (2018), and Garza (2026) demonstrating that mesocclisis is more restricted than if it were merely a case of phonological metathesis. Regardless of what analysis of mesocclisis one adopts, the existence of these examples complicates the view of Spanish subject-verb agreement morphemes as it makes the 3PL *-n* look very much like a clitic given the criterion in (30). This generalization, along with the existence of the phenomenon, is sufficient for our purposes here, and it is not necessary to get into the weeds of these different analytical treatments in this paper.

One point worth mentioning, though, is that this phenomenon is not restricted to imperatives, as it has been suggested in the literature (e.g., Arregi & Nevins 2018). It can be observed in other areas of colloquial Spanish, such as with enclisis in a non-finite embedded clause.

- (34) Ellos quiere -n ir =se-n. (Rivera-Castillo 1992:427)
 they want -3PL go.INF=SE-3PL
 ‘They want to leave.’

For a syntactic treatment of this phenomenon, see Garza & Ordóñez (2026). Even outside of imperative contexts, then, the 3PL morpheme *-n* behaves as a clitic according to the diagnostic stated in (30).

2.3 Presence of a default

Turning now to another diagnostic that has been presented in the literature to differentiate between cliticization and agreement, I show another instance of Spanish complicating existing explanations of the relevant phenomena. This diagnostic is taken from Preminger (2009; 2014), and it centers around the presence of a default morpheme. This diagnostic is stated as follows:

- (35) *Diagnostic for “pure” agreement vs. clitic doubling* (Preminger 2009:623; 2014:205)
 Given a scenario where the relation $\mathcal{R}$ between an agreement-morpheme $\mathcal{M}$ and the corresponding full noun phrase $\mathcal{F}$ is broken, but the result is still a grammatical utterance:
- $\mathcal{M}$ shows up expressing “default” phi-features $\Rightarrow \mathcal{R}$ is “pure” agreement.
 - $\mathcal{M}$ disappears entirely $\Rightarrow \mathcal{R}$ is clitic doubling.

While it is certainly true that, when clitic doubling fails to obtain, the clitic is not present at all (as opposed to having some kind of default/expletive clitic fill the place where it may be expected to appear) (see examples (23), (24), and (27)), it is not necessarily the case that a lack of subject-verb agreement in Spanish results in the presence of an overt default form. See, for instance, example (8), repeated here.

- (36) a. Se= censura-n los documentos. (Ormazabal & Romero 2024:445-6)
 SE= censor -3PL the documents
 b. Se= censura-Ø los documentos.
 SE= censor -3SG the documents
 ‘The documents were censored.’

Under the view that third person singular agreement is actually a result of a lack of agreement in a language such as Spanish (Béjar 2003; Oltra-Massuet & Arregi 2005; Mensching & Remberger 2006; Gravely et al. 2023, a.o.), an observation which is certainly related to the idea that third person constitutes a lack of a specified person feature value in the language (Benveniste 1966; Kayne 2000; Nevins 2007; Grishin 2023), we see the disappearance of any agreement morpheme altogether in cases where agreement fails to obtain: e.g., (36b).

Thus, the subject-verb agreement paradigm of Spanish starts to look like clitic doubling, according to the diagnostic in (35), specifically point (b). See the following table for the present indicative inflectional paradigm of the Spanish verb *ver* ‘to see’.

(37) PRES.IND paradigm of *ver* ‘to see’

	VERB ROOT	THEME VOWEL	PHI-AGREEMENT
1SG	<i>v-</i>	<i>-e</i>	<i>-o</i>
2SG			<i>-s</i>
3SG			<i>-∅</i>
1PL			<i>-mos</i>
2PL			<i>-is</i>
3PL			<i>-n</i>

Here, subject-verb agreement for third person singular is characterized by the lack of an overt agreement morpheme, which stands out from all the other overt agreement morphemes. While there is some degree of variation across tenses and lexemes, there is a strong generalization that 3SG agreement is always characterized by the lack of an overt morpheme.

There is a theoretical issue present in Preminger’s diagnostic of how one would go about differentiating between a null default morpheme and the lack of a morpheme altogether, and it seems that there is no allowance for this kind of distinction in (35). This theoretical consideration casts doubt on this diagnostic’s explanatory power, as do the empirical facts concerning Spanish 3SG agreement (which can be contrasted with, say, the distribution of 3SG.PRES *-s* in English). Nevertheless, this diagnostic as it is presented by Preminger (2009; 2014) very clearly makes Spanish subject-verb agreement look like cliticization.

2.4 Formal resemblance to strong pronouns

A further diagnostic from Preminger (2014) intended to differentiate between cliticization and agreement concerns the status of the relevant morphemes as resembling the given language’s series of strong pronouns (Preminger 2009:648; 2014:78). While this diagnostic is not stated formally as in (35), Preminger states that the Basque morphemes that he analyzes “resemble the corresponding strong pronouns because they are clitics” (2014:78).

From what I understand, the reasoning here is as follows: clitics look like strong pronouns, therefore clitics are pronouns. Conversely, “true” agreement affixes must be something different, since they apparently lack this formal resemblance to strong pronouns.

This logic here stands out to me as problematic since there is no *a priori* reason that pronominal forms must resemble one another in their formal realizations. In fact, they often do not. See the following (simplified) Spanish pronoun paradigm, in which I include verbal phi-agreement morphemes as well.

(38) Spanish pronominal paradigm

	NOM (STRONG)	OBJ (STRONG)	CLITIC (ACC)	PHI-AGR
1SG	<i>yo</i>	<i>mí</i>	<i>me</i>	<i>-o</i>
2SG	<i>tú</i>	<i>tí</i>	<i>te</i>	<i>-s</i>
3SG.F	<i>ella</i>		<i>la</i>	<i>-∅</i>
3SG.M	<i>él</i>		<i>lo</i>	
1PL	<i>nosotr{os/as}</i>		<i>nos</i>	<i>-mos</i>
2PL	<i>vosotr{os/as}</i>		<i>os</i>	<i>-is</i>
3PL.F	<i>ellas</i>		<i>las</i>	<i>-n</i>
3PL.M	<i>ellos</i>		<i>los</i>	

While it is certainly true that clitics resemble personal pronouns, the issue I take here is with what Preminger suggests that it means for a given morpheme to not resemble a pronominal form. We can see several phi-agreement morphemes in this table that actually do resemble the pronominal forms. Looking at the 1PL sequence of the paradigm, the subject-verb phi-agreement morpheme *-mos* clearly and unambiguously resembles the clitic pronoun *nos*, which itself is clearly contained within the strong pronoun *nosotros* (or *nosotras*). To a lesser extent, we can observe a formal similarity between the 2PL agreement morpheme *-is* and the clitic pronoun *-os* (which is again contained within the strong pronoun). To an even lesser extent, the 1sg agreement morpheme *-o* resembles the strong nominative pronoun *yo*, though this point is admittedly weaker since *-o* does not appear across the entire inflectional paradigm, unlike the 1PL and 2PL agreement morphemes (see the following sub-section). Once again, though, this diagnostic as it is presented by Preminger (2014) makes several Spanish subject-verb agreement morphemes look like clitics.

2.5 Contextual (in)variance

The following diagnostic that is complicated by the Spanish data regards formal invariance and the possibility of allomorphy, specifically allomorphy with tense (Nevins 2011). See the following.

- (39) *Tense-invariance diagnostic* (Nevins 2011:958)
 An independent syntactic diagnostic for clitic vs. affix status is tense-invariance: a clitic, being a D element, will not show allomorphy across tenses.

According to Nevins, clitics are expected to be contextually invariant with respect to tense, while “true” phi-agreement morphemes are expected to show tense-based allomorphy. This generalization is a more relaxed version of a diagnostic stated by Zwicky & Pullum (1983): that clitics do not show any kind of formal contextual variance at all, a claim that is rejected by Nevins and which I also reject (since contextual variance of clitics in Romance is quite easy to come by).

Nevins states that “clitics must be tense invariant” (2011:960). He does not, however, explicitly state that phi-agreement morphemes (which he assumes to be technologically distinct from clitics) must show tense allomorphy 100% of the time⁴. The issue that Spanish presents, though, is that there is actually a relatively low degree of tense-based allomorphy within the verbal inflectional paradigm at all. This fact, coupled with the other clitic-like properties (according to the relevant diagnostics) for Spanish subject-verb agreement morphemes presented in this section, serves to suggest that making a rigid technological distinction between phi-agreement and cliticization and expecting such a distinction to be empirically borne out within any language is problematic.

In addition to resembling the pronominal form (38) and being optional under certain conditions (15), the 1PL verbal agreement morpheme is also contextually invariant with respect to tense. Across every tense paradigm for every verb, the morpheme *-mos* is present when there is 1PL agreement. See the following example, using the regular verb *censurar* ‘to censor’ as an example.

⁴ Yuan (2021:157) notes that this diagnostic is actually inconclusive for elements which do not show tense allomorphy, since the diagnostic does not specify whether or not non-clitics must show contextual variance. This point is certainly true; however, given the other ways in which many of these Spanish agreement morphemes behave like clitics, the fact that they are (completely to mostly) contextually invariant is further evidence that there should not be such a sharp divide between clitics and “true” agreement morphemes.

(40) Tense invariance with 1PL *-mos*

	VERB ROOT	THEME VOWEL	TENSE	PHI-AGR
PRES.IND	<i>censur-</i>	<i>-a</i>	$-\emptyset$	<i>-mos</i>
PRET			<i>-ba</i>	
IPFV.IND			<i>-re</i>	
FUT.IND			<i>-ría</i>	
COND		$-\emptyset$	<i>-e</i>	
PRES.SBJV			<i>-ra</i>	
IPFV.SBJV		<i>-a</i>	$-\emptyset$	
IMP.AFF		$-\emptyset$	<i>-e</i>	
IMP.NEG				

Also, in addition to being optionally realized in many contexts (8)-(14) and appearing in what we can easily call a clitic cluster (31)-(34), the 3PL verbal agreement morpheme *-n* is further contextually invariant with respect to tense. See the following.

(41) Tense invariance with 3PL *-n*

3PL	VERB ROOT	THEME VOWEL	TENSE	PHI-AGR
PRES.IND	<i>censur-</i>	<i>-a</i>	$-\emptyset$	<i>-n</i>
PRET			<i>-ro</i>	
IPFV.IND			<i>-ba</i>	
FUT.IND			<i>-rá</i>	
COND			<i>-ría</i>	
PRES.SBJV		$-\emptyset$	<i>-e</i>	
IPFV.SBJV		<i>-a</i>	<i>-ra</i>	
IMP.AFF		$-\emptyset$	<i>-e</i>	
IMP.NEG				

There is further a very low degree of contextual allomorphy with second person agreement forms, which only show contextual allomorphy with affirmative imperative forms (the *-s* morpheme on 2SG preterit verbs can be seen in many colloquial varieties of Spanish). Subject-verb agreement for 1SG is really the only paradigm in which there is a high degree of allomorphy, alternating between an *-o* form (present indicative), an *-é* form (preterit, future indicative), an *-í* form (preterit) and a zero form elsewhere. Additionally, there are present indicative irregular forms such as *-oy* (seen with verbs such as *estar* ‘be’, *ser* ‘be’, *dar* ‘give’, and *ir* ‘go’).

Thus, according to the diagnostics discussed here, 1PL and 3PL subject-verb agreement strongly resemble clitics. Additionally, given these diagnostics’ accommodations of exceptions, one could make the case that the 2SG and 2PL subject-verb agreement morphemes *-s* and *-is* are also clitics.

2.6 Summary of the empirical facts

According to the diagnostics presented thus far in this section, the Spanish data present a seemingly complicated picture. To some extent, doubled argument clitics in Spanish fit the criteria for being “true” phi agreement, such as the fact that they have a major tendency to in fact not be optional. Much more compelling, however, is the evidence that subject-verb agreement morphemes largely

behave like clitics according to these tests, in terms of their distributional, combinatoric, and formal properties. A further complication is that, within the series of Spanish subject-verb phi-agreement morphemes, there is considerable variation as to which morphemes display which properties of cliticization: 1PL *-mos* and 3PL *-n*, for instance, exhibit more clitic-like properties than 1SG *-o* in terms of optionality⁵, morpheme stacking, and contextual invariance.

Thus, we observe a kind of spectrum of cliticity when looking at the argument clitic and phi-agreement morphemes discussed so far in this paper, with argument clitics displaying many (but not all of the) properties of cliticization according to the relevant diagnostics, and some phi-agreement morphemes displaying a relatively high number of clitic-like properties, while others still show even fewer clitic-like properties (it should be noted that none of the Spanish phi-agreement morphemes do not show any clitic-like properties). See the following table.

(42) Clitic-like properties of Spanish clitics and agreement morphemes

	Argument clitics				Phi-agreement morphemes				
	<i>me/te/nos/os</i>	<i>se</i>	<i>lo(s)/la(s)</i>	<i>le(s)</i>	<i>-mos</i>	<i>-is</i>	<i>-n</i>	<i>-s</i>	<i>-o</i>
Optional			Rioplatense	✓	✓	✓	✓		
Stackable over CL	✓	✓	✓	✓			✓		
Lack of default	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Resembles pronoun	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓			✓
Tense - invariant	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	

The Spanish data do not suggest such a clear underlying distinction between phi-agreement and cliticization than has been suggested elsewhere (Zwicky & Pullum 1983; Preminger 2009; 2014; Nevins 2011; Kramer 2014; Baker & Kramer 2018, Yuan 2021; a.o.). I use these empirical facts to motivate a unified syntactic analysis of the two phenomena in the following section, which obtains greater empirical coverage and theoretical simplicity than many prior approaches that draw a hard line between the technology involved in cliticization and in phi-agreement.

Before moving on, though, I quickly mention two additional diagnoses from the literature that I consider to be largely inconclusive for Spanish.

⁵ It is not the case that 1sg agreement can never be optional, though, even though no examples of it were shown in Sect. 2.1. Félix Fonseca Quesada (p.c.) notes the following optional alternation in Costa Rican Spanish:

- (ii) a. Acab-o de llega -r yo. (Costa Rican Spanish, Fonseca Quesada p.c.)
 finish-1SG of arrive-INF I.NOM
 b. Acaba-Ø de llega -r yo.
 finish -3SG of arrive-INF I.NOM
 ‘I just arrived.’

Thus, it is not the case that no instance of a 1sg agreement morpheme can never be optionally realized, and it would further be an error to claim that 1SG subject-verb agreement exhibits zero clitic-like properties according to the diagnostics from the literature (see also the formal resemblance to the 1SG nominative pronoun noted in Sect. 2.4).

The first of these diagnostics concerns interpretive differences between clitics and “true” agreement morphemes. Yuan (2021), analyzing Inuktitut and Kalaallisut, does not rely on any morphological diagnostics, arguing that they are largely inconclusive to differentiate between the two phenomena (a claim to which I am initially sympathetic). Instead, however, Yuan claims that clitic doubling should be associated with interpretive differences at LF, as it constitutes genuine pronominal movement, while “true” phi-agreement has no such effects due to its underlying explanation as mere feature copying, which is argued to not trigger any semantic effects.

As it turns out, this diagnostic is not valid for making any claims about Romance, as it has been sufficiently argued that clitic doubling in Romance—and in other languages such as Greek—is by and large not associated with any observable semantic effects (Angelopoulos 2019; Angelopoulos & Sportiche 2021), with Angelopoulos & Sportiche (2021) explaining that any interpretive effects that may initially appear to be associated with clitic doubling actually arise from the properties of the XPs that are doubled by the clitics (see also Belloro 2007). This fact from Romance and Greek thus raise the question of whether or not there is sufficient motivation in the first place to believe that cliticization—i.e., pronoun incorporation as head movement (Roberts 2010)—should be expected to give rise to any interpretive effects at all.

The second diagnostic that I do not consider valid here concerns locality restrictions with clitic doubling and “true” phi-agreement. Preminger (2009) argues that different locality restrictions hold of clitics and “true” phi-agreement morphemes. Without a number of caveats on the status of clitic climbing in Romance (i.e., that it involves restructuring—a claim which is not universally accepted (see Kayne 1989)), however, this claim is difficult to maintain. In Spanish, which allows clitic climbing, both subject-verb agreement and clitic climbing are (for the most part) only capable of crossing finite clause boundaries: i.e., both are subject to the Phase Impenetrability Condition (PIC) (Chomsky 2000; 2001). Descriptively, then, the locality restrictions are the same. There are a certain number of contextually restricted exceptions within Romance such as hyper-agreement across a finite clause boundary with certain psych-predicates in some colloquial Spanishes (Fernández-Serrano 2017; 2022) as well as, notably, the possibility of clitic climbing over certain finite clause boundaries in Salentino (Terzi 1996). Therefore, the exceptions are not asymmetric. Accounting for all of these possible exceptions to the PIC—in addition to meticulously searching for any possible concession that these locality constraints may not be the same for Spanish argument clitics and subject-verb agreement morphemes—is an undertaking that I consider mostly tangential to the main argument of this paper. As such, it is sufficient to state here that the locality constraints for these two classes of morphemes in Spanish bear a striking similarity to one another and do not support a view of these phenomena as being technologically distinct.

Having not spent too much time on them, I note that the inconclusivity of these tests for Spanish further supports a reality in which we cannot reliably empirically distinguish between cliticization and “true” phi-agreement in this language using the diagnostics that have been put forth in the literature. I now turn to how this information should be implemented for an analysis and theoretical understanding of the relevant phenomena.

3 Theoretical concerns

As shown in Sect. 2, there is not such a clean distinction between argument cliticization and subject-verb phi-agreement morphology in Spanish. I take this fact as an endorsement of a unified analytical approach to these phenomena, deriving them via a single explanatory mechanism. Logically, there are two possibilities that could be (and have been) pursued to this end: an analysis

of clitics as agreement (as in Suñer 1988; Brandi & Cordin 1989; Paparounas & Salzmann 2024; Jambrović 2025:92) or an analysis of agreement as cliticization (as in Taraldsen 1992; 1993; Barbosa 1995; Ordóñez 1997; Ordóñez & Treviño 1999). Given that, according to the diagnostics from Sect. 2, the supposed phi-agreement morphemes largely behave like clitics (as opposed to the other way around), I pursue the latter approach of agreement as cliticization within the theoretical framework of the Strong Minimalist Thesis (SMT). As I argue here, this explanation is more closely aligned with the goals of Minimalist theorizing than the alternatives (i.e., clitics as agreement or a non-unified approach). This argument has two points: first is what the role of Agree should be in SMT-based explanations of syntactic phenomena, which I adopt in this paper, (Sect. 3.1), and the second is based in Kayne’s (2005) Principle of Decompositionality (Sect 3.2). With these points, we can unify cliticization and phi-agreement under a Merge-based approach to clitics as functional licensing heads (Sportiche 1996), which license their arguments via Form Copy (FC) and External Merge (Chomsky 2021) (Sect. 3.3).

3.1 Agree and the SMT

According to the quotes in (3)-(6), cliticization is characterized by movement of a pronominal element such as D^0 somewhere into the verbal/tense/inflectional domain, while “true” phi-agreement involves the copying of features from a goal to a probe and the spellout of those features on the probe, which is also located in the verbal/tense/inflectional domain.

In the SMT, the only operation in the narrow syntax is Merge (Chomsky et al. 2023; Chomsky 2024). Looking at the technology said to underly “true” phi-agreement, we have the valuation of unvalued features on a probe and the spellout of those features on the probe, driven by the operation Agree (Chomsky 2000; 2001). Agree in this sense involves two components: Match and feature copying (via Attract), defined as follows.

- (43) *Match* (Chomsky 2000:122)
 Agree is a syntactic operation taking place between a probe P and a goal G in the domain of P, $D(P)$, between which a Matching relation holds.
- a. Matching is feature identity.
 - b. $D(P)$ is the sister of P.
 - c. Locality reduces to “closest c-command”.
- (44) *Attract* (Chomsky 1995:273)
 K attracts F if F is the closest feature that can enter into a checking relation with a sublabel of K.

Thus, Agree is defined as Match + Attract. Attract is crucially a distinct operation from Internal Merge (Chomsky 2000; 2001). Let us now see how compatible this formulation of Agree is with the claim of the SMT that Merge is the only structure building operation in the narrow syntax.

Under the SMT, this view of Match can be reduced to Minimal Search (MS), defined as follows, which is a third-factor principle of computational efficiency—or “natural law” (Chomsky 2021:12)—meaning that it can be used “for free” in Minimalist explanations.

- (45) *Minimal Search* (Chomsky 2020:36)
 A third factor principle that says look for the closest copy and don’t look any further.

Thus, the first component of Agree is compliant with the SMT. The advantageous possibility of reducing Match to MS has been pointed out elsewhere (Ke 2019; 2023; Krivochen 2023; Collins 2025). More concerning is the status of feature copying, which is again distinct from Merge (Chomsky 2000; 2001). Even many MS-based formulations of Agree still posit the existence of a non-Merge-based syntactic component such as valuation via feature copying (Ke 2019; 2023).

In fact, the notion of valuation via feature copying itself to satisfy some interface condition that mandates the deletion of unvalued features for interpretability is a notion that directly contradicts the SMT’s goal of having syntactic explanations not rely on interface conditions imposed on narrow-syntactic derivations (Chomsky et al. 2023). It should be noted that there do exist formulations of Agree that attempt to divorce the need for valuation from the need to satisfy interface conditions (e.g., Preminger 2014; Deal 2024), though, even in these formulations, there is a necessary stipulation of non-Merge-based feature copying.

We see, then, that Agree as feature copying is necessarily at odds with the goals of the SMT to reduce the set of syntactic operations to Merge and nothing else. Thus, an unified analysis of cliticization and subject-verb agreement that explains both phenomena as a by-product of Agree (e.g., Paparounas & Salzmann 2024, a.o.) is undesirable within the goals of the SMT. As I show in the remainder of this section, an explanation of these phenomena using the technology involved in cliticization is able to reduce both of them to instances of External Merge, thereby conforming to the SMT (see similar enterprises in Collins 2017; 2025; Blümel 2023; Roberts 2024).

3.2 Principle of Decompositionality

Current formulations of Agree introduce various unnecessary technological complications into the narrow-syntactic computational system. This fact has perhaps served as the motivation for Chomsky et al. (2023) to shift the locus of agreement phenomena to the externalization system (i.e., the sensory-motor interface), though I attempt here show that at least a subset of agreement phenomena—subject-verb agreement morphology—can be handled in the narrow syntax with Merge, aligning their analysis with a Merge-based approach to cliticization (as in Sportiche 1996).

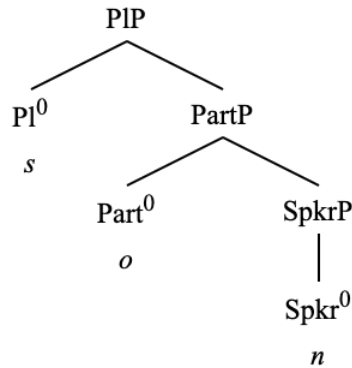
Following the intuition that features are syntactic primitives that can indeed be manipulated in the narrow syntax in such a way as to interact with other syntactic structures, let us consider Kayne’s (2005) Principle of Decompositionality.

- (43) *Principle of Decompositionality* (Kayne 2005:212)
UG imposes a maximum of one interpretable syntactic feature per lexical item.

It is independently advantageous in the SMT framework to adopt the Principle of Decompositionality in order to rule out non-Merge-based approaches to combining features such as bundling or late insertion (on this point, see Kayne 2005; Collins & Kayne 2023; Collins 2024).

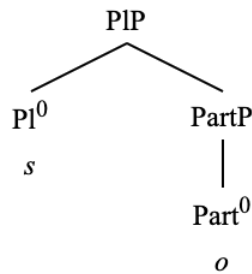
In this view, there is a one-to-one correspondence between a syntactic feature and a given head (i.e., a lexical item). A single feature must be represented on one head, and a single head must contain only one feature. Following Harris (1994), Kayne (2000), and Pescarini (2007), the internal structure of a pronominal expression such as the 1PL clitic *nos*, would then be as follows:

- (46) Internal structure of 1PL clitic *nos*



Then, the internal structure of the 2PL pronominal clitic *os* would be as follows. Note that the features of the 2PL clitic are a proper subset of the 1PL clitic, and the form of 2PL *os* is transparently contained within 1PL *nos*.

- (47) Internal structure of 2PL clitic *os*



In these examples, I do not include a DP layer in the structure of these 1P and 2P pronominal expressions following the observations in Kayne (2000: Ch. 8) that Romance first and second person pronominals lack the distributional and morphological properties of DPs. Additionally, it is not necessary to posit a universal DP layer for all nominals within the SMT (Chomsky et al. 2019:248; Blümel & Holler 2022).

Furthermore, these morphemes are spelled out in accordance with the generalization known as the Mirror Principle (Baker 1985), defined here.

- (48) *The Mirror Principle* (Baker 1985:375, emphasis my own)
Morphological derivations must directly *reflect* syntactic derivations (and vice versa).

The Mirror Principle as it is traditionally conceived of is often derived by the formation of complex heads via head movement (e.g., Travis 1984; Baker 1988). Although Chomsky (2021:30) specifically disposes of head movement as a syntactic operation within the SMT, there is work attempting to reconcile head movement effects within the SMT using Internal Merge (e.g., Roberts 2024). Additionally, there are formulations of head movement as underlyingly involving XP movement, which is not ruled out in the SMT (e.g., Matushansky 2006; see also Kayne 1975). If one does not wish to concede head movement in any sense within the SMT, however, the Mirror Principle could easily be cast as a property of amalgamation (as in Chomsky 2021:35-6), which is a condition of externalization that applies to specific linearization domains. There is the additional

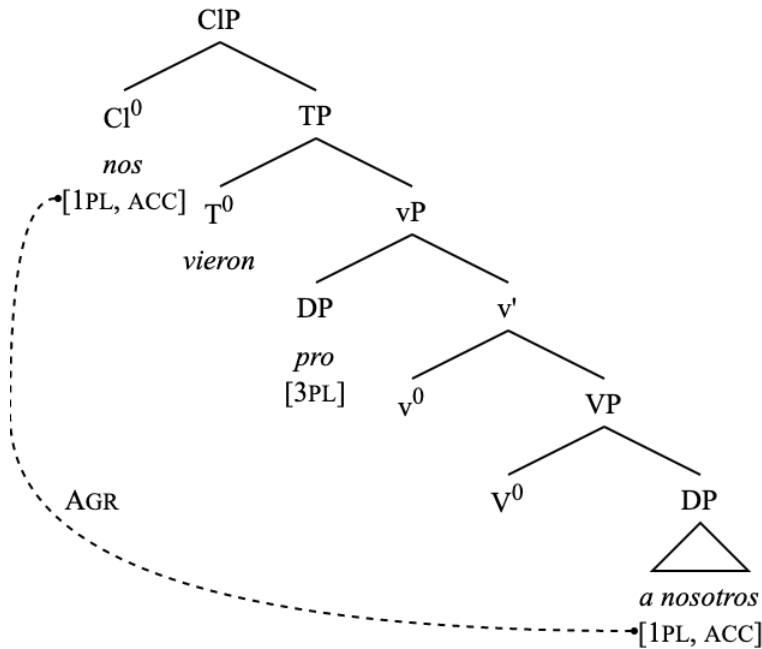
possibility to consider that an SMT-compliant formulation of head movement is a component of the amalgamation operation, perhaps defining the specific linearization domains to which amalgamation applies. I believe that the facts that I bring up concerning proclitic versus enclitic environments in Sect. 4.2.3 endorse such a view.

Independently of their spellout order, if a given head is visible to third factor computational operations such as MS as its content (i.e., the feature), then features can interact with other syntactic objects by being introduced into a derivation via External Merge as a head X^0 , thus allowing the formation of complex pronominal expressions as in (46)-(47) via Merge only. As I go on to show, this assembly of features via Merge is also sufficient to explain the formal, distributional, and combinatoric properties of argument clitics and subject-verb phi-agreement morphemes in Spanish.

3.3 Clitics as licensing heads: External Merge + Form Copy

Here, I adopt the explanation of clitics from Sportiche (1996). Under this view, “a clitic is analyzed as heading its own projection and as licensing...a particular property of a designated argument agreeing with it in the relevant features (person, number, gender, Case, etc.)” (Sportiche 1996:213). Thus, argument clitics of the variety discussed in this paper are analyzed as “pure agreement” and are responsible for Case-licensing arguments. This is shown for a Spanish direct object below.

(49) Cliticization, as in Sportiche (1996): *Nos vieron a nosotros* ‘They saw us’



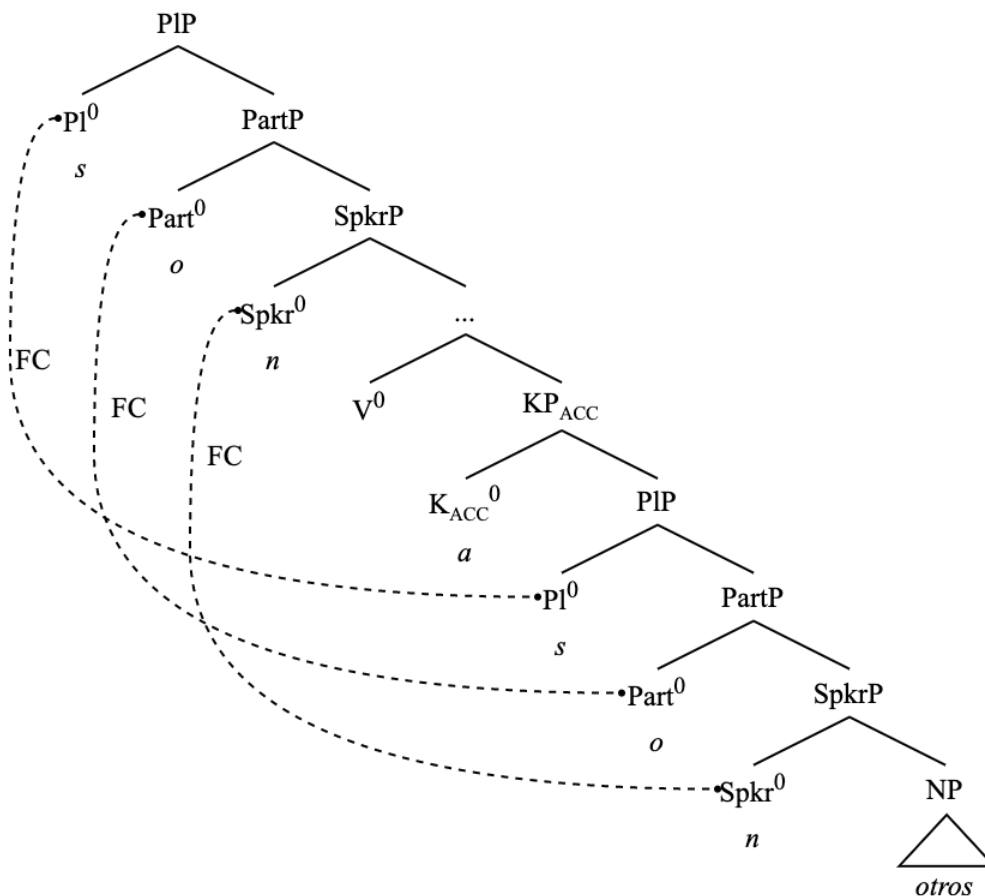
This account of cliticization is often referred to as a “base generation” account (e.g., Manzini & Pescharini 2022), given that the clitics are externally Merged in their positions in the clausal spine (as opposed to moving there). There is a question to be asked at this point of how the licensing relation between the clitic and the argument that it licenses is expected to obtain without Agree (i.e., without feature copying).

Here, the SMT provides the answer in terms of Form Copy (FC), which can apply to syntactic objects to establish a Copy relation (a kind of redundancy) between those objects (Chomsky 2021; Blümel 2023) via the third factor computational principle MS.⁶

- (50) *Form Copy (FC)* (Chomsky 2021:20)
 FC...appropriates Σ [Search] from the third factor toolkit and operates at the phase level, keeping to MS to select an element X, then searching for a structurally identical element Y under the conditions on Σ , and assigning the relation *Copy* to $\langle X, Y \rangle$.

The ability of FC to license arguments and replace Agree has been explored (Blümel 2023; Roberts 2024), with Blümel (2023) noting specifically that FC can hold of two featurally identical elements that have each been externally Merged (as opposed to just having FC connected to Internal Merge). Thus, the Agree relation in (50) can be recast in terms of FC via MS. Given the Principle of Decompositionality, the sequence of functional heads actually involved in licensing the features of arguments should be significantly expanded as to mirror the internal structure of pronouns in (46)–(47), with each functional head licensing a distinct relevant feature of a given argument. The following structure will be expanded upon throughout the paper.

- (51) Clitic licensing, one feature per head: *Nos...a nosotros*



⁶ It may very well be possible to not have to state FC as an independent operation at all (Collins 2022; 2025).

This technology—functional head argument licensing via External Merge + FC via MS—shall be used to explain both argument cliticization and subject-verb agreement morphology in Spanish, with the latter simply being a specialized instance of the former. Therefore, this analysis takes two seemingly separate phenomena and unifies them under a Merge-based account. While the derivation in (51) may initially look more complicated than the one in (50), it is a reflection of a syntactic engine with as few computational stipulations as possible: Merge as the only structure-building and structure-manipulation operation, with third factor principles used as needed.

Given the expressly stated goal of the SMT is to seek maximal simplicity in natural language systems (Chomsky 2021) and the notable aim Minimalist theorizing to “eliminate unnecessary distinctions” (Roberts 2010:5), this analysis presents a major theoretical advantage. See a very similar treatment of English subject-verb agreement from Collins (2025).

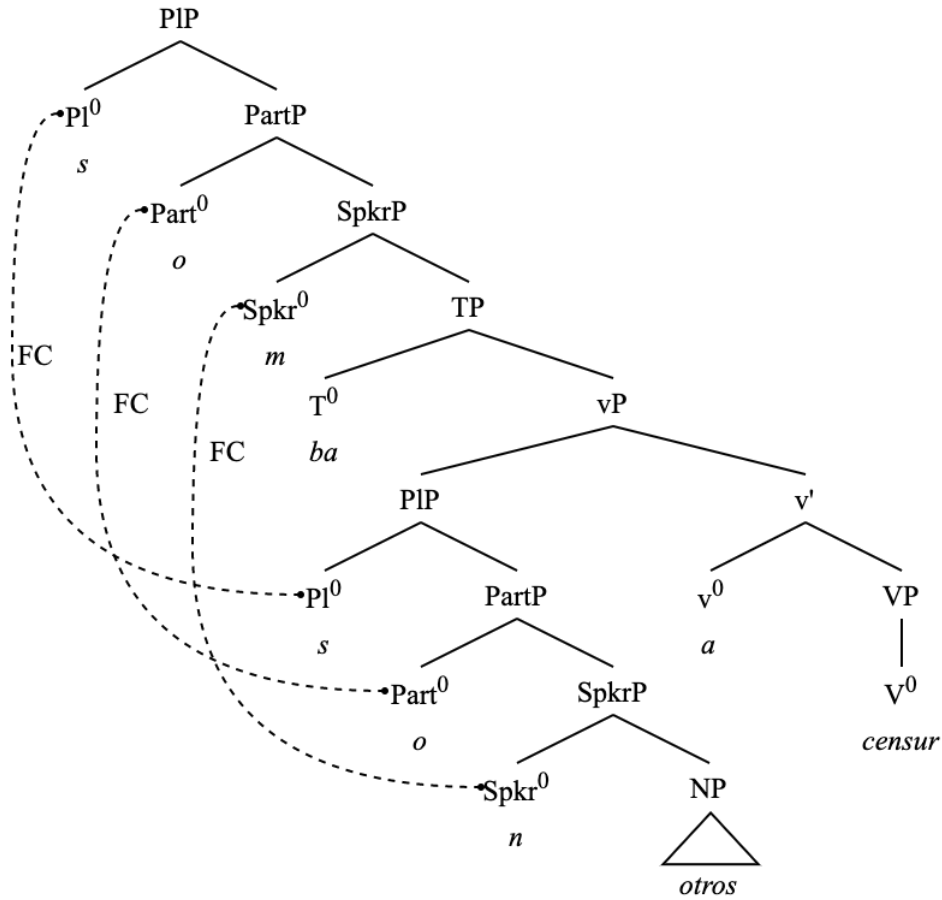
4 A unified analysis

As I show now, the unified Merge-based approach to cliticization and subject-verb agreement carries several empirical advantages as well: in addition to sufficiently accounting for both the surface similarities and differences between argument cliticization and subject-verb agreement (Sect. 4.1), this account captures several notable clitic interaction effects with multiple object clitics, and various cases of mesoclefts (Sect. 4.2). It further offers a cohesive explanation of the situation in Spanish regarding subject licensing, nominative Case, pro-drop, and the EPP (Sect. 4.3). I additionally demonstrate how the Merge-based approach is able to handle a high degree of dialectal and crosslinguistic variation with respect to clitic combinatorics in Romance (Sect. 4.4).

4.1 Spanish subject agreement clitics

Given the expressed goal of unifying argument clitics and subject-verb agreement under a treatment of both phenomena as cliticization as described in Sect. 3.3, let us now consider the adequacy of the sequence of projections sketched out in (51) to derive subject-verb agreement morphology. See the following example with the 1PL imperfect tense regular verb *censurábamos*.

(52) 1PL subject-verb agreement as cliticization

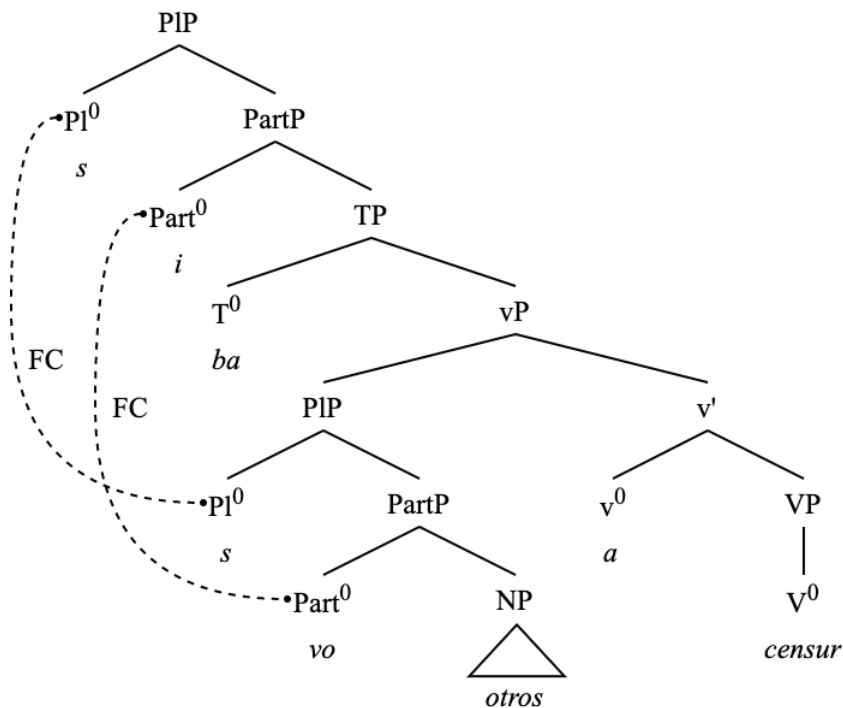


Here, the clitic heads along with the tense domain, the theme vowel, and the verbal lexeme form a single linearization/amalgamation domain, leading to the realization of the verb and subject-verb agreement morphology together as *censur-a-m-o-s*.

I consider the distinction between *-m-* (52) and *-n-* (51) for the Spkr morpheme in 1PL agreement to be immaterial: see the realization of 1PL agreement as *-nos* in New Mexican Spanish (Rivera-Castillo 1992:432), as well as closely related languages in which the *-m-* surfaces instead of *-n-* in 1pl pronominal forms, such as Ladino and Asturian. Note that this first person *-m-* morpheme seems to be the same one that is realized in the 1SG clitic pronoun *me*.

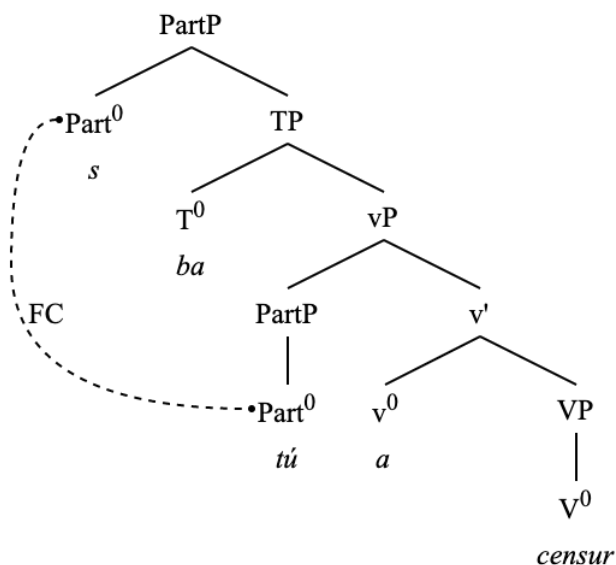
Given that 2PL forms a subset of 1PL as in (46)-(47), the same series of clitic morphemes is able to easily realize 2PL verbal agreement as well, in which we can take the vowel *-i-* to be a reduced variant of the *-o-* that we see in 1PL agreement and the 2PL clitic pronoun.

(53) 2PL subject-verb agreement as cliticization



In second person singular contexts, as in the following example, this participant head is realized in most varieties of Spanish as *-s*. See below with the 2sg imperfect regular verb *censurabas*.

(54) 2SG subject-verb agreement as cliticization



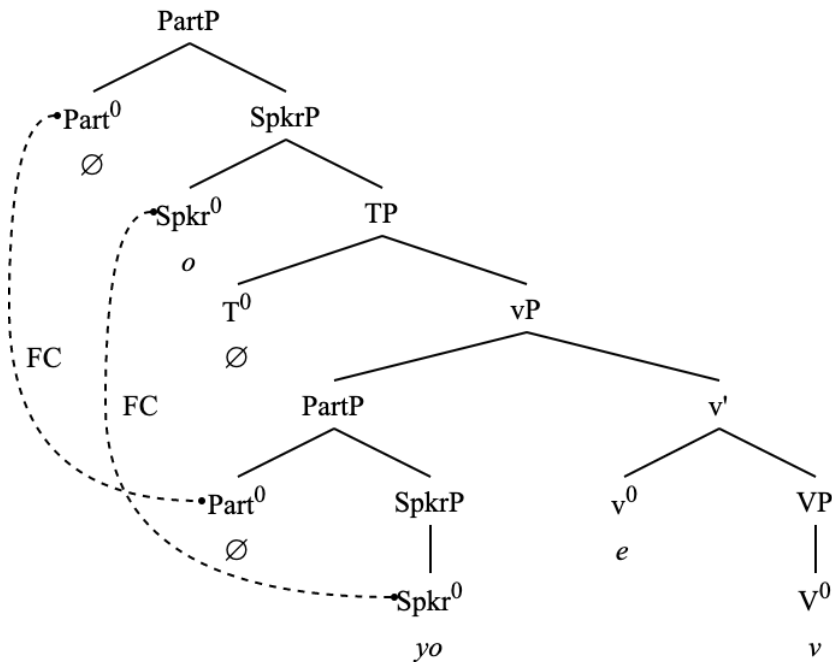
Interestingly, the singular participant morpheme is spelled out as *-i* as well in Chilean Spanish, showing a uniformity of the spellout of the participant head regardless of number:

- (55) a. ¿Está-*i* trabajando? (Chilean Spanish, Bishop & Michnowicz 2010:424-5)
 be -2SG work.PROG
 ‘Are you working?’
 b. ¿Ha -*i* hablado con alguien?
 have-2SG speak.PART with someone
 ‘Have you spoken with someone?’

Further regarding the realization of participant features, this approach to subject-verb agreement as cliticization easily derives cases of number “unagreement”, as in (15), an observation which has been made by Ordóñez & Treviño (1999). Here, these clitic heads are able to license features of arguments even when those features are not spelled out on the arguments themselves⁷.

For present tense indicative, we see that the speaker information is encoded by the morpheme *-o*, which I take to be the form of the Speaker head in singular environments for subject-verb agreement, though in different tenses this is spelled out in different ways. In this system, we can connect the higher degree of tense allomorphy (Sect 2.5) with 1SG agreement with the fact that this Speaker head is closest to T^0 when all of these clitics are present. See the following example with 1SG indicative present ‘see’, *veo*, which I have chosen as the theme vowel and 1SG agreement morpheme do not coalesce in this example.

- (56) 1SG subject-verb agreement as cliticization



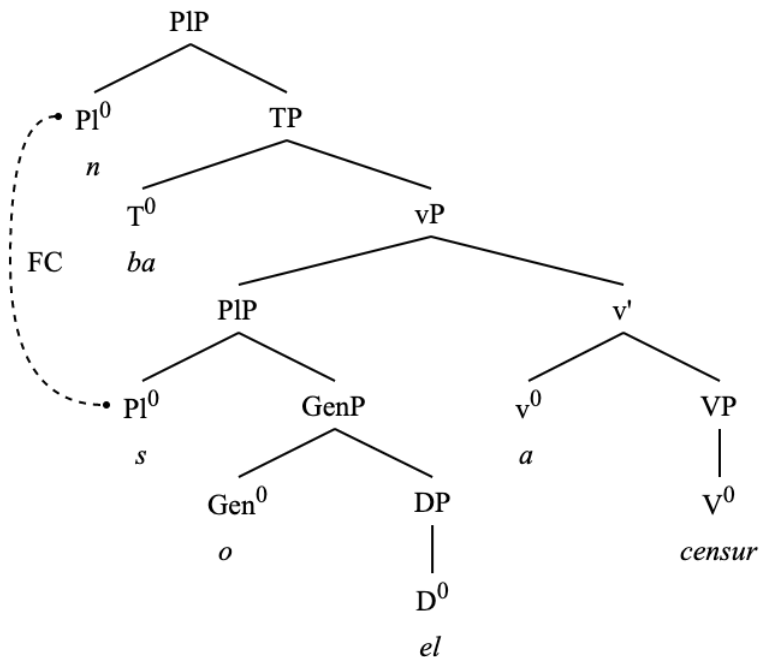
It must be the case that the Participant head is also present for 1SG, since speaker features necessarily cooccur with participant ones (Harley & Ritter 2002) (i.e., first person simply is featurally represented as [Part[Spkr]], with no variation), but that $Part^0$ receives a null exponence in most 1SG environments. It is worth mentioning, though, that there are several present tense 1sg agreement forms that are realized as *-oy* (/oi/) such as *doy* ‘give.1SG’, *voy* ‘go.1SG’, and *soy/estoy*

⁷ For detailed discussions as to why participant features are not able to be spelled out on certain arguments in number unagreement in Spanish, I direct the reader to observations by Saab (2006; 2013) and Höhn (2016).

‘be.1SG’, which can in this system be taken to be a realization of Spkr^0 as *-o* and of Part^0 conditionally being realized as *-i* yet again.

For the sake of completing the paradigm, we have 3PL *-n*, which I take to be the realization of just the plural head, since third person is a deficiently represented person in Spanish (Sect. 2.3). In the following structure, I include a head D^0 in the third person pronominal expression *ellos* ‘they.M’, given the clear connection between third person pronouns and determiner morphology in Spanish (Kayne 2000, a.o.).

(57) 3PL subject-verb agreement as cliticization



Here, there is no cooccurrence restriction between plural and any other feature, as there is between speaker and participant, for instance. This is evidenced by the fact that morphemes that encode plurality can show up in any environment regardless of person (or something like gender), as well as in the absence of any person features, as in (57). I use this observation to explain numerous peculiarities of Spanish plural agreement/cliticization in Sects. 4.2 and 4.4.

4.2 The object clitic field

As I have shown, subject-verb agreement in Spanish is best conceived of as a series of licensing projections for specific features of nominal subjects. Obviously—as in (51) and the original ideas of Sportiche (1996)—these projections can be extended to the object clitic domain as well. Given the myriad interaction effects between dative and accusative object clitics, I believe that it will be fruitful to pursue the idea that both dative and accusative objects are licensed by the same series of licensing clitic heads, inspired by Ciucivara’s (2009) approach to clitic interaction effects in Romanian.

I do not attempt to cover the distribution of reflexive clitics for now (including impersonal *se* and personal/ethical datives, though the latter perhaps fall beyond the scope of this paper as non-

argument clitics) as they show various exceptions to these generalizations, such as no PCC effects, so they are ignored for the remainder of this subsection.

In a sequence of two argument object clitics in Spanish, it is most often the case that the first one is dative and the second is accusative, though this claim is not without exception (Bonet 1991). In a DAT-ACC clitic sequence, several restrictions can be observed. First, it is not possible accusative clitic that is first or second person: only the dative clitic may be first or second person, thus demonstrating the well-known PCC (Person-Case Constraint) effects for Spanish clitic clusters (Bonet 1991; Ordóñez 2002, a.m.o.).

- (58) a. $\acute{E}l \{me/ \quad te/ \quad nos/ \quad os=\} \quad lo= \quad dio.$
 $he \{me.DAT/you.DAT/us.DAT/ y'all.DAT\} \quad it.M.ACC \quad give.3SG.PAST$
 'He gave it to me/you/us/y'all.'
- b. $\acute{E}l \{me/ \quad te/ \quad le=\} \quad \{me/ \quad te/ \quad nos/ \quad os=\} \quad dio.$
 $he \{me.DAT/you.DAT/him.DAT\} \quad \{me.ACC/you.ACC/us.ACC/y'all.ACC\} \quad give.3SG.PAST$
int: 'He gave me/you/us/y'all to me/you/him.'

Additionally, in a sequence of two third person clitics, the first clitic must be realized as *se*, instead of the standard third person clitic that contains an *l*- form (e.g., *le*, *les*, *lo*, etc.), which is known as the "spurious-*se*" rule (Aissen & Rivas 1975).

- (59) a. $*Le= \quad lo= \quad pag-u\acute{e}.$ (Aissen & Rivas 1975:1)
 $him.DAT=it.ACC= \quad pay-1SG.PAST$
- b. $Se=lo= \quad pag-u\acute{e}.$
 $SE=it.ACC= \quad pay-1SG.PAST$
 'I paid him for it.'

Given the observation from Kayne (2000) that the *s*- form in the *se* clitic corresponds to third person while the *l*- form in the other third person object clitics corresponds to a feature [D], we can take the generalizations in (58) and (59) to mean that, in a DAT-ACC sequence of two clitics, person features are only visible on the dative clitic.

Furthermore, number distinctions are neutralized in spurious-*se* contexts, which, along with gender being neutralized on dative clitics for most Spanish speakers to begin with, leads to third person dative clitics being ambiguous for both number and gender in DAT-ACC clitic clusters.

- (60) $Se(*s)= \quad lo= \quad dije.$
 $SE(*PL)= it.ACC= \quad say.1SG.PAST$
 'I said it to him/her/them.'

Further, when the referent of the dative is plural and the accusative singular, it is possible for many speakers to realize a plural -*s* on the accusative (De Mello 1992; Hoff & Schwenter 2021).

- (61) $A \quad ellos \quad les= \quad remit-ieron \quad un \quad libro, \quad y \quad yo \quad se=lo \quad -s \quad =di.$ (De Mello 1992:168)
 $to \quad them \quad them.DAT=send \quad -3PL.PAST \quad a \quad book \quad and \quad I \quad SE=it.ACC-PL=gave.1SG.PAST$
 'They sent them a book, and I gave it to them.' (*lit*: '...and I gave them to them.')

Plurality from the dative clitic appearing on the accusative clitic is not limited to spurious-*se* contexts, either. Hoff & Schwenter (2021) note that plural morphology can appear on an accusative clitic whose referent is singular in the presence of the 1PL dative clitic *nos* in Mexican Spanish.

- (62) Eso a todos nos= lo -s =ha -n dicho. (Hoff & Schwenter 2021:520)
 that to all us.DAT=it.ACC-PL=have-3PL say.PART
 ‘They’ve told all of us that.’ (*lit*: ‘That, they’ve told them to all of us.’)

In fact, in such cases it is not necessary for the plural morpheme to appear on the dative at all, which is very similar to the examples of mesoclisism from Sect. 2.2. It is documented that, in enclitic environments such as infinitivals, progressives, and affirmative imperatives, the plural -s in 1PL and 2PL dative clitics can be exclusively realized following the accusative clitic (Pato & De Benito (P&D) 2017).

- (63) Si quiere-n un meme pída =no =lo -s. (P&D 2017:123)
 if want -3PL a meme ask.IMP.AFF=us.DAT=it.ACC-PL
 ‘If y’all want a meme, ask us for it.’

- (64) Lo.que queré-is para traé -r =o =lo -s y luego enviá-r
 what want -2PL for bring -INF =y’all.DAT=it.ACC-PL and then send-INF
 =o =lo -s. (P&D 2017:129)
 =y’all.DAT=it.ACC-PL
 ‘What y’all want for bringing to y’all and then sending to y’all.’

Further, unlike the mesoclisism examples of Sect. 2.2, this phenomenon is attested in proclitic environments as well (Rivera-Castillo 1997; P&D 2017).

- (65) La amiga de nuestra madre no= lo -s= cont -ó todo. (P&D 2017:123)
 the friend of our mother us.DAT= it.ACC-PL=tell -3SG.PAST all
 ‘Our mom’s friend told it all to us.’

There is still, though, a striking similarity between these clitic cluster examples and the mesoclisism examples in Sect. 2.2 in terms of the variable realization of a plural morpheme with the possibility for doubling and extraposition. In fact, in this system, there really is no underlying difference between these phenomena—given that clitic doubling and subject-verb agreement are explained in the same way—aside from where they can be realized, which I explain further on.

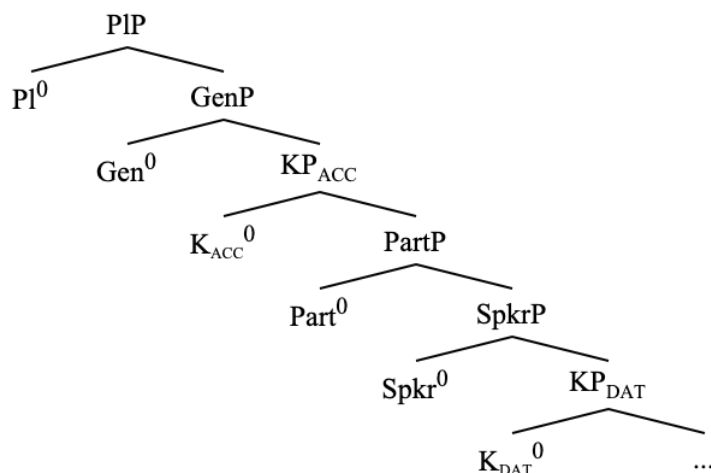
Based on the examples shown here in (58)-(65), we can make some broad generalizations about the realization of features in Spanish DAT-ACC clitic clusters. Person features—first and second person as well as the third person *s-* of spurious-*se*—are only realized on the dative clitic, while gender features and the D morpheme *l-* can only be realized on the accusative clitic. Additionally, while plural features for both dative and accusative are generally able to be realized on the accusative clitic, they are only conditionally realizable on the dative (in other words, there is significant interaction between the number features of each clitic in the cluster). These generalizations are summarized in the following table.

(66) Featural realizations in DAT-ACC clitic clusters

	DAT	ACC
PERS	✓	*
NUM	Conditionally realized	✓
GEN	*	✓
D(-)	*	✓

Following others who have made similar generalizations (e.g., Banfi 1999; Ciucivara 2009), I take these facts as evidence that dative and accusative clitic licensing fields make use of shared licensing heads for their relevant features—person, gender, and number—while licensing Case with distinct heads. See the following.

(67) Object clitic licensing field

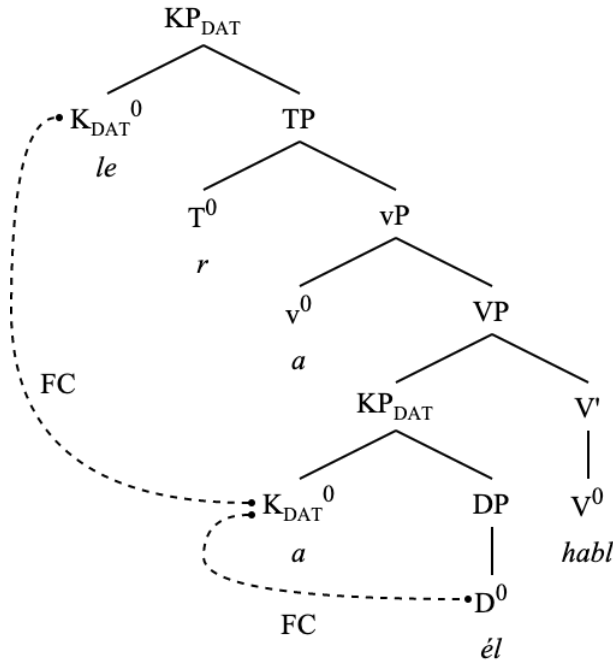


4.2.1 Spurious-se

Given the connection between determiners and third person clitic morphology in Spanish (or third person in general) (Kayne 2000; Bernstein 2008; Longobardi 2008; Saab 2013; Bernstein et al. 2025a), as well as the connection between differential object marking (DOM) with *a* and clitic-doubled objects (Jaeggli 1982, a.o.), I assume that the D morphology *-le* of third person object clitics is realized in the object clitic field via a tripartite link between the K head in the object clitic licensing field, a K head (in the sense of Collins (2024); the locus of DOM) internal to the thematic nominal argument, and the D head internal to the thematic nominal argument. In this view, a feature [D] is more or less synonymous with third person in Spanish, given that third person is the lack of a more specific person value and that D morphology is incompatible with any overt realizations of first or second person. Let us take an example such as the following, with a nonfinite verb and a direct object clitic.

- (68) Habla-r =le a él.
 speak-INF =him.DAT to he
 ‘To talk to him.’

(69) Third person object clitic morphology derived via FC



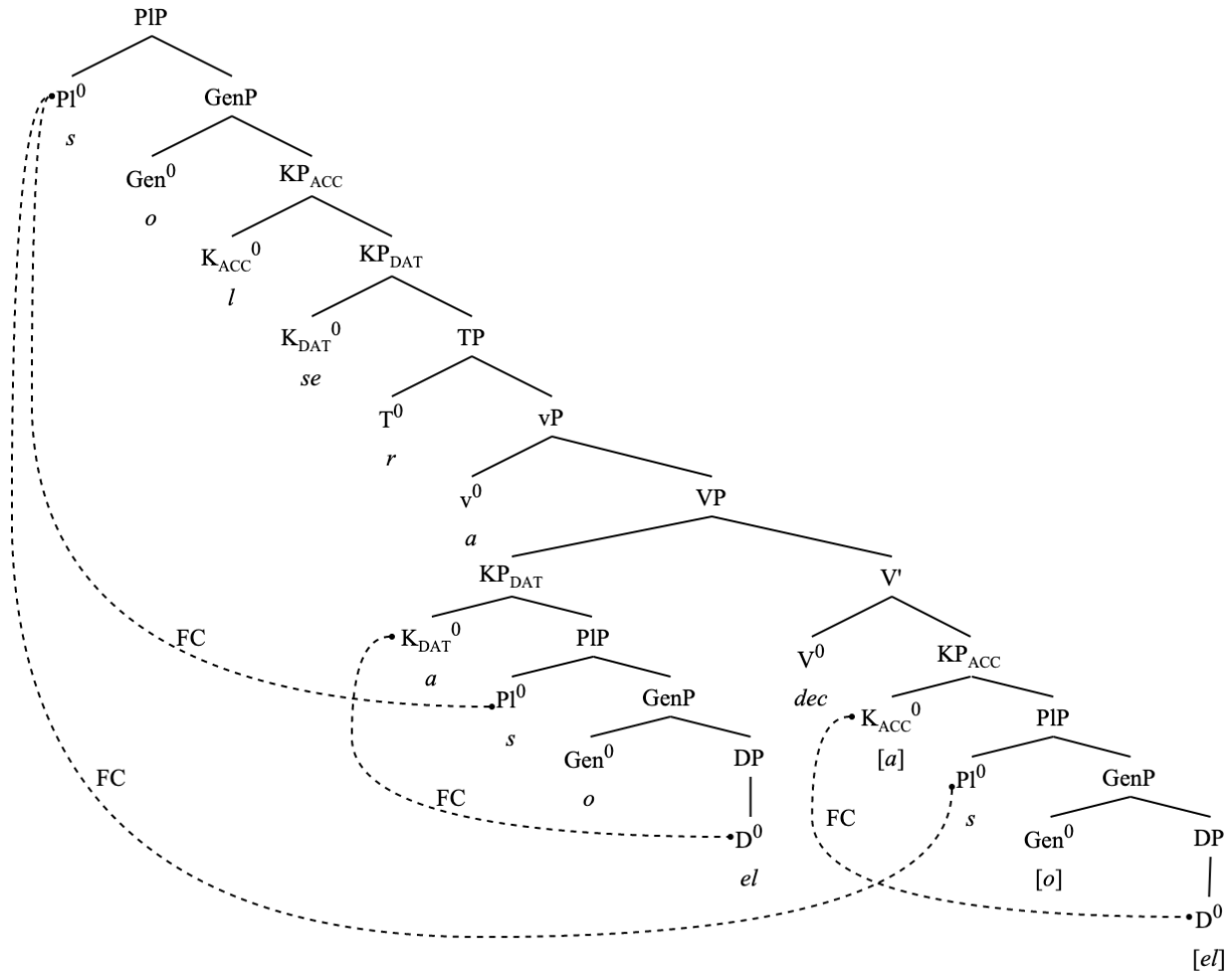
Given that FC holds between two features under identity, there is an obvious question of how FC is established between a head D^0 and a head K^0 . Here, it may be useful to posit an uninterpretable D feature on the argument-internal K head, whose presence as an uninterpretable feature would not violate the Principle of Decompositionality. It seems to me, though, that the appropriate role of uninterpretable features within the SMT remains to be seen in its entirety.

With first and second person object clitics whose doubled counterparts have DOM (e.g., *Nos vieron a nosotros* ‘They saw us’), K^0 is not overtly spelled out in the object clitic field as no FC was established between the lower K^0 and a D head internal to the 1PL nominal, as there is not one present.⁸ With non-DOM third person argument objects, there is no doubling as there is no KP internal to the argument with which to establish FC. These observations are certainly connected to the fact that subject-verb agreement shows no third person morphology, and nominals which undergo subject-verb agreement generally cannot cooccur with DOM (more on this in Sect. 4.3).

With these considerations in mind, we can see the derivation for a DAT-ACC clitic cluster for two third person arguments and how a number feature is shared between them. I do not include FC links for features other than number in the following example for the sake of not overcomplicating the visualization, but it should still be assumed that FC holds between the clitic licensing heads and the relevant features (e.g., Case, gender) within the nominal arguments.

⁸ There is variation regarding this point. In some varieties of Spanish, it is possible to realize a dative clitic morpheme *le* in the absence of D/third person features on the doubled nominal. See the redundant/stylistic *le* of Chilean Spanish (Muñoz-Pérez 2026), in which a 1SG dative *me* can be realized as *me=le*. In such examples, it must be the case that the relevant language varieties allow the dative KP head to be overtly realized without having undergone FC with a DP head.

- (70) Decí-r =se =lo -s a ellos.
 say -INF =3.DAT=it.ACC-PL to they
 ‘To say it/them to them.’



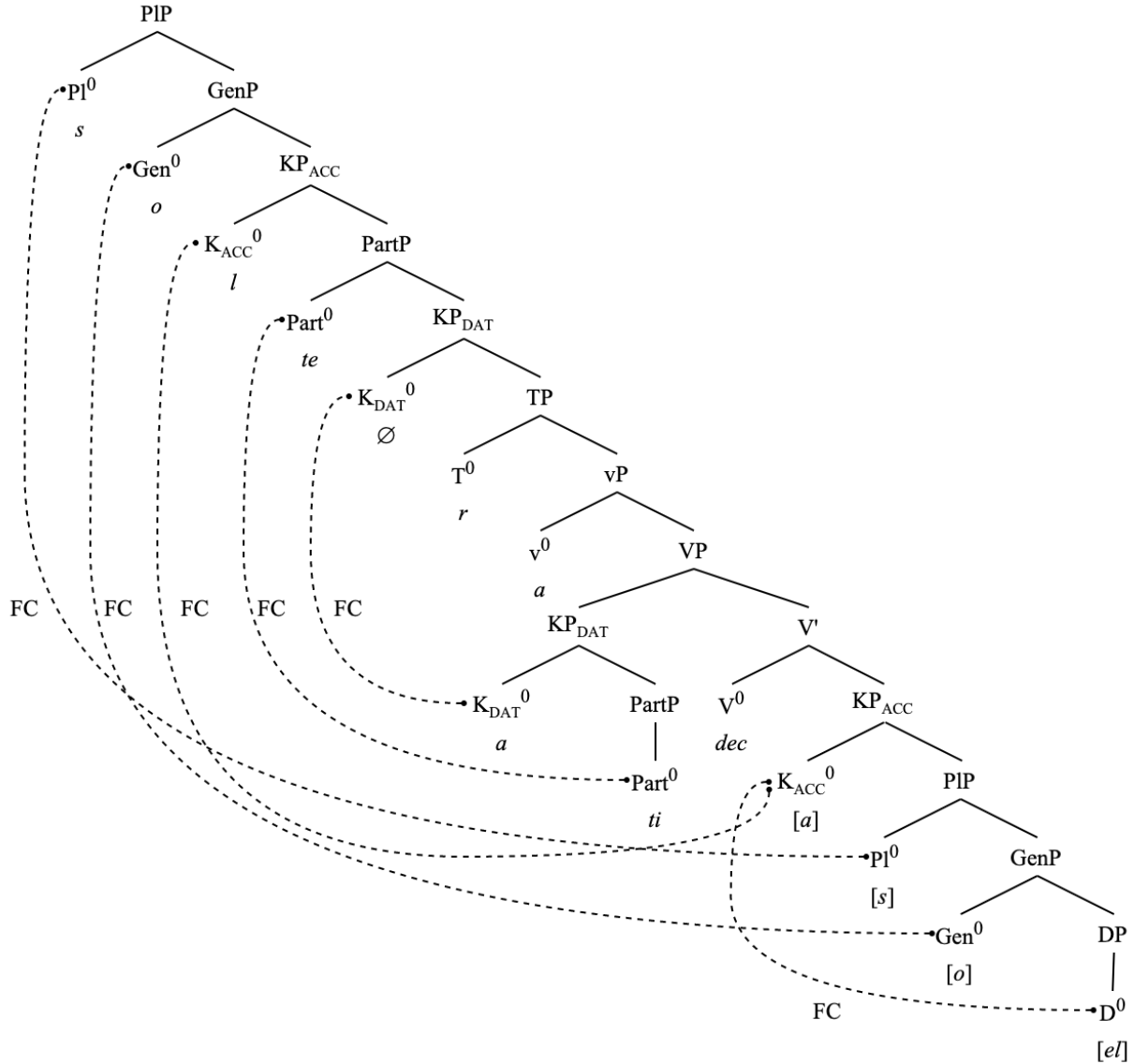
Crucially, in the case of having only a plural dative argument, the plurality need not show up in the clitic field at all—but, when it does, it is only realizable on the accusative clitic. This fact tracks with the apparent optionality of plural feature licensing more generally, a point to which I return in Sect. 4.4. The spurious-*se* effect (i.e., that K_{DAT}^0 is not spelled out as *l-*) itself can be explained in terms of the fact that *s-*, a reflex of third person, and *l-*, a reflex of a D feature, in this system share a common point of origin, which is the head D^0 within the thematic argument⁹. Under this view, *s-* is a contextually restricted variant of *l-*. It seems that the *s-* form here is employed to differentiate between K_{DAT}^0 and K_{ACC}^0 , which at no point enter into an FC relation with one another, though I leave a detailed explanation of the exact distribution of the *s-* form (e.g., Kayne 2018) in this system aside for the purposes of this paper. It is worth noting, though, that the spurious-*se* rule is relatively uncommon across Romance languages, even those which have both *s-* and *l-* determiner forms, making Spanish unique in this regard.

⁹ This observation is indeed consistent with the diachronic situation of *s-* forms and *l-* forms in Romance determiners. On this, see Bernstein et al. 2025b.

4.2.2 Participant-bearing clitic clusters

Moving on to what happens with a first or second person clitic-doubled argument, let us see how a first or second person dative clitic with a third person accusative clitic is derived in this system of shared licensing heads. See the case of a 2SG dative clitic and a third person accusative clitic.

(71) Licensing of 2SG DAT & 3PL ACC arguments *decir=te=los* ‘To say them to you’



Given that there is only one participant licensing head available, both a dative and accusative participant-bearing (i.e., first and second person) argument are not able to have this feature licensed via cliticization. The dative clitic is the only one that can be marked for person in a DAT-ACC clitic cluster due to the ordering of the relevant heads. This is how PCC effects are derived.

We can now take together the derivation of number feature sharing in (70) and the derivation of person hierarchy effects in (71) to explain the data in (62)-(65): namely, that the plural feature of a 1PL or 2PL dative clitic is able to be optionally realized for many speakers on the accusative

clitic, with or without being realized on the dative itself. This feature sharing thus allows for a 1PL DAT + 3SG ACC to be realized as *no=lo-s*, and for a 2PL DAT + 3SG ACC to be realized as *o=lo-s*, and for the same realization of 1PL/2PL DAT + 3PL ACC. Since the participant (and speaker) features of the dative are not realized directly adjacent to a plural head, there is a question of why a 1PL+3PL clitic cluster *no=lo-s* is not indistinguishable from a 1SG+3PL clitic cluster *me=lo-s*. The answer to this question relies on FC and the particular licensing conditions of first and second person features.

Participant (and speaker) features licensed are licensed via FC under an additional condition of identity with a particular referring expression. The unique licensing properties of first and second person features have indeed been documented (Béjar & Rezac 2003; Baker 2008; Preminger 2014; Raynaud 2020; Storment 2025, a.o.). These licensing requirements must then be part of the interpretative conditions imposed on these features, as it does not make sense in any framework to conceive of a given (not unvalued/uninterpretable) feature as carrying its own particular licensing conditions in the narrow syntax. In this way, the licensing requirements of first and second person features can be connected to the necessity of these features to be interpreted as part of a pronominal referring expression. Consider that the first or second person interpretation is not available in (15) without the 1PL/2PL agreement morphemes, repeated here.

- (72) a. Los estudiantes tiene-n mala memoria.
 the students have-3PL bad memory
 ‘The students have bad memory.’ ([+participant] interpretation not available)
 b. Los estudiantes tene {-mos/-is} mala memoria.
 the students have {-1PL/ -2PL} bad memory
 ‘We/y’all the students have bad memory.’ ([+participant] interpretation necessary)

As third person in Spanish is actually a by-product of the lack of an explicitly projected person feature, there is no such licensing condition for third person DPs, as evidenced by the fact that no subject-verb agreement morphemes surface with 3SG subjects (Sect 2.2), and cliticization can often not be realized for third person objects (Sect 2.1). It should be noted that this is not a licensing condition on formal identity, but on interpretive identity, which can be seen from the fact that doubling with 1PL *nos* and *-mos* can obtain with constituents which are interpreted as 1PL despite not containing a 1PL pronominal form. See the following.

- (73) a. Nunca *nos=* vio *a mí y a Batman* en el mismo lugar.
 never us.ACC=see.3SG.PAST to me and to Batman in the same place
 ‘He’s never seen me and Batman in the same place.’
 b. *Batman y yo* esta-mos en el mismo lugar.
 Batman and I be -1pl in the same place
 ‘Batman and I are in the same place.’

Thus, a DAT-ACC clitic cluster with a 1PL dative cannot be realized as *me=lo-s*, even when the plural feature of the dative is not realized adjacent to the dative’s (speaker+)participant morphemes, as to do so would not conform to the interpretive conditions on participant-bearing pronominals.¹⁰

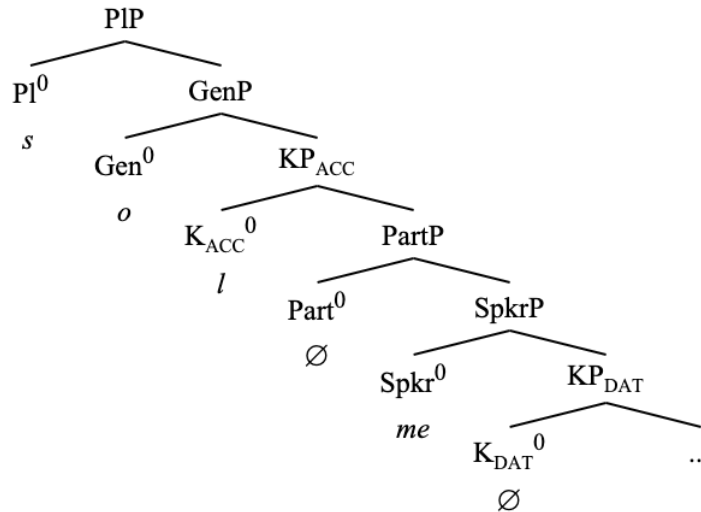
¹⁰ The impossibility of this kind of number mismatch with first or second person cliticization is definitely not something that we should expect to hold universally, especially give its explanation here that does not entirely take

As for the cases in which the plural *-s* morpheme actually is realized adjacent to the participant morphemes of the dative, which is certainly the “norm” across varieties of Spanish, a perhaps counterintuitive aspect of this analysis is that cases of a 1PL *n-os=lo(s)* 2PL or *o-s=lo(s)* DAT-ACC clitic cluster must involve the movement of the plural morpheme from the position in which it is externally merged—as in (70) and (71)—onto the dative person morphemes. This extraposition of the plural morpheme in the case of 1PL+3SG *no-s=lo*, or doubling of the plural morpheme in cases of 1PL+3SG/PL *no-s=lo-s*, is an effect I take to be derived by head movement/amalgamation, and, given that there is no such effect possible with a third person dative (i.e., *se(*s)=lo(s)*, as in (60)), we can connect this amalgamation effect to the interpretive conditions on participant-bearing pronominals, along with some notion of formal preferences that language users are known to exhibit. In other words, it may be slightly easier (i.e., more economical) for speakers to interpret a form *no-s* as being 1PL than it is to interpret *no* with no adjacent plural morpheme as such. This preference is then realized during the amalgamation operation to realize the plural morpheme as adjacent to the participant morpheme, either via movement or doubling.

4.2.3 Amalgamation/linearization domains: Proclisis and enclisis

The aforementioned amalgamation effects with the placement of the plural *-s* are possible because the DAT-ACC clitic sequence corresponds to a single linearization/spellout domain in accordance with the Mirror Principle. Thus, the following heads are externalized in a “bottom-up” order.

(74) Linearization domain of the object clitic field for *me=los* ‘ME.DAT=THEM.ACC’



place in the narrow syntax. Within Romance, we can indeed find this kind of variation. In certain varieties of French, it is possible to realize a 1SG subject clitic with a 1PL subject (Hull 1988; King et al. 2004; Kayne 2008).

- (iii) Je= nous= tracasser-ions pas. (Hull 1988:242)
 SCL.1SG=1PL.REFL=worry -1PL.COND NEG
 ‘We wouldn’t worry.’

In this example, though, the 1PL morphology is still realized on the reflexive clitic and, crucially, on the subject-verb agreement. It is not the case, then, that the interpretive conditions on the realization of the 1PL pronominal are not realized anywhere in the clause.

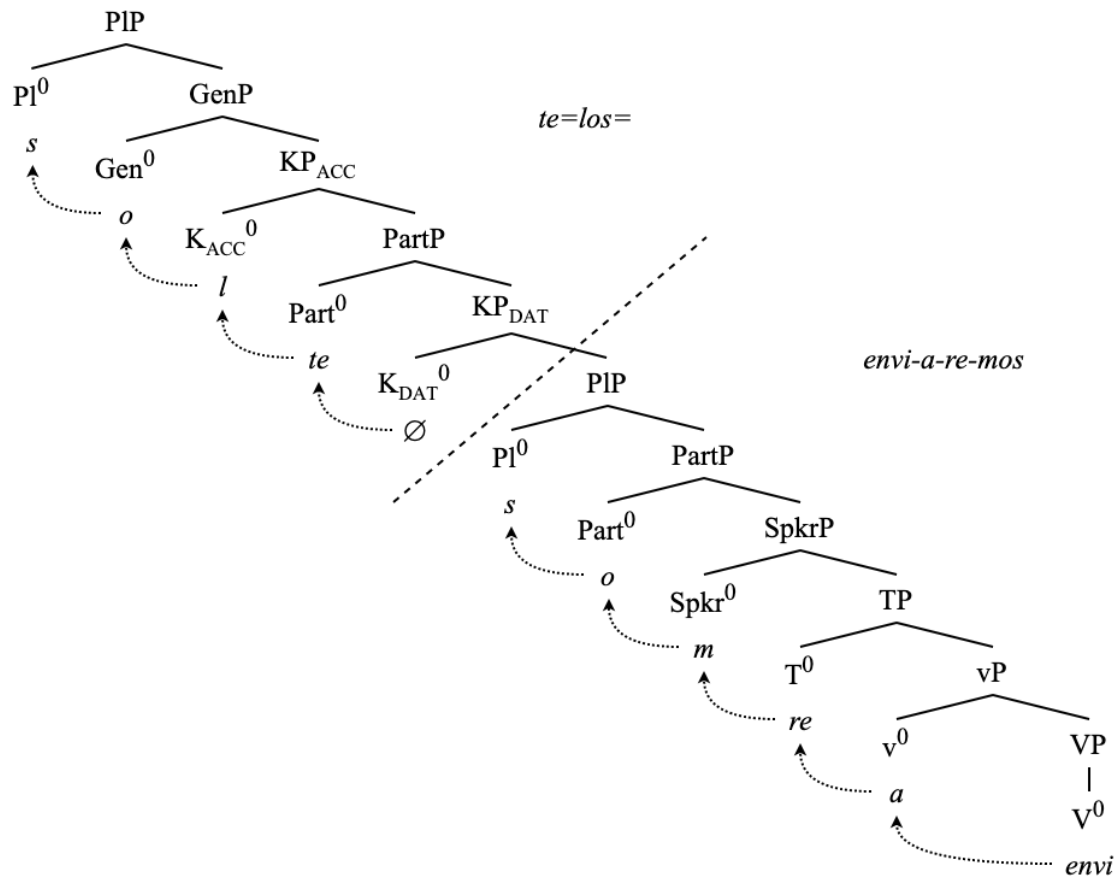
As amalgamation applies to this sequence of heads as a single linearization domain, interaction between these heads at the level of amalgamation is possible, such as with mesoclis in enclitic environments.

Additionally, in this system, this sequence of heads of the object clitic field correspond to a single morphological word (loosely defined here) in the same way that the verb along with its tense and subject-verb agreement morphology correspond to a single word. As such, the fact that the dative and accusative clitics are separated orthographically in proclisis environments (though notably not in enclisis environments) is somewhat misleading. Evidence that such an analysis is on the right track is the fact that these clitics cannot be split up via clitic climbing—a phenomenon which I do not analyze in depth here—when both clitics correspond to arguments of the embedded clause.

- (75) a. Quier-o dá -r =te =lo. (Terzi 1999:107)
 want -1SG give-INF=you.DAT=it.M.ACC
 b. Te= lo= quier-o dar -r.
 you.DAT=it.M.ACC=want -1SG give -INF
 c. *Te= quier -o da -r =lo.
 you.DAT=want -1SG give -INF =it.M.ACC
 ‘I want to give it to you.’

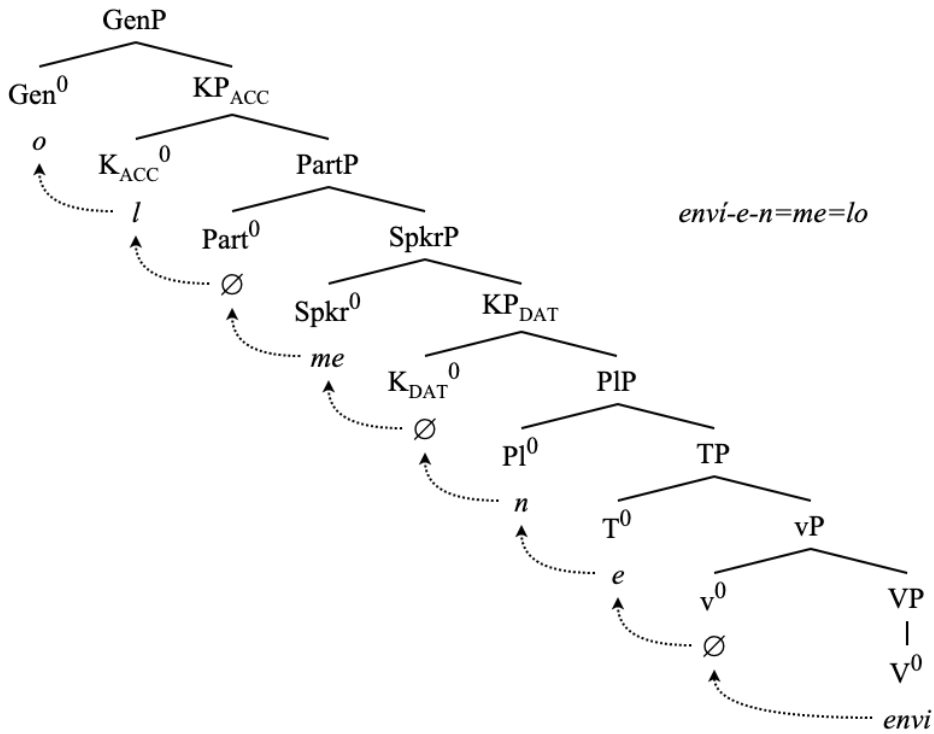
As such, in monoclausal proclisis environments with finite verbs (barring affirmative imperatives), the verb—along with tense and subject-verb agreement morphemes—correspond to a single linearization domain, while the object clitic field corresponds to another. See the following example, with thematic arguments and FC links omitted for the sake of clarity.

- (76) Te= los= envia -re -mos.
 you.DAT=them.M.ACC= send -FUT-1PL
 'We will send them to you.'



In enclisis environments, however, the verb, tense morphology, subject-verb agreement, and object clitic field all correspond to a single linearization domain.

- (77) Envíe -n =me =lo.
 send.IMP.AFF-3PL =me.DAT=it.M.ACC
 ‘Send(PL) it to me.’



In a head-movement-based explanation of these amalgamation effects, the difference between enclisis and proclisis environments here is that movement of the verb is triggered high enough as to move through the object clitic field as well, thus triggering the coalescence of two linearization domains that would otherwise remain separate (as in proclisis). This kind of verbal-head-movement account of enclisis is pursued by Kayne (1994), and works particularly well here.¹¹

Thus, in enclisis environments, there can be observed many interactions between the subject-verb agreement field and the object clitic field that are not possible with proclisis (e.g., Sect. 2.2).

- (78) a. Hága -n =lo -n. (Kayne 2010:159)
 do.IMP.AFF-3PL =it.M.ACC -3PL
 ‘Do(PL) it.’
 b. *No lo -n= haga -n.
 no it.M.ACC-3PL=do.IMP.NEG -3PL
 ‘Don’t(PL) do it.’

The difference between these two environments is that the subject-verb agreement field and the object clitic field share an amalgamation domain with enclisis, thus making these kind of interaction effects possible (as it is also possible within a DAT-ACC clitic cluster, which always

¹¹ An alternative approach not using head movement could be to connect specific linearization domains to a notion of phasehood, with finite verbs forming a distinct phase from the object field and non-finite verbs not creating a phase boundary. This kind of explanation would work quite well for enclisis with nonfinite verbs, but would leave an explanatory gap in terms of enclisis with affirmative imperatives. As such, I go with the head movement analysis here.

corresponds to a single amalgamation domain), whereas no such effects are possible across multiple amalgamation domains in the case of proclisis.

In this analysis, then, mesocclisis 3PL *-n* and the effects observed in DAT-ACC clitic clusters with the plural morpheme *-s* are uniformly analyzed as amalgamation effects corresponding to a given linearization domain in the syntax. I have further considered the role of head movement in deriving these effects within an SMT framework. For an additional unified treatment of these phenomena, see Garza & Ordóñez (2026). In Sect. 4.4, after defining the role of argument licensing via cliticization in some more detail, I connect these considerations to some observations on the patterns of linguistic variation that are allowed within this unified, Merge-based approach to cliticization and agreement, specifically concerning how phenomena like mesocclisis only affect plural morphemes.

4.3 Spanish subject licensing

Given that the function of argument clitic heads is to license particular features of arguments (Sportiche 1996), and that subject-verb agreement in this system is actually just a given instantiation of these clitic heads, it follows that subjects are licensed via cliticization (formerly agreement) in the same way that Case-marked objects must be licensed via cliticization. In this way, the analysis presented here falls into alignment with a very large body of literature discussing the role of verbal agreement in the licensing of subjects in pro-drop languages like Spanish (Rizzi 1982; Pollock 1989; 1997; Taraldsen 1993; Barbosa 1995; Alexiadou & Anagnostopoulou 1998; Ordóñez & Treviño 1999; Holmberg 2010, a.m.o.), as well as more recent observations on the apparent lack of nominative Structural Case in Spanish (Etxepare & Gallego 2020).

In this system, the major difference between subject and object licensing is the position of the clitic heads that license these arguments: subjects are licensed by a sequence of clitic heads located directly above TP that always form an amalgamation domain with the lexical verb, whereas objects are licensed by a higher sequence of clitic heads that do not always form an amalgamation domain with the lexical verb. Thus, as opposed to movement of the subject argument into a position to be Case-licensed (as in a non-pro-drop language such as English), licensing occurs via FC with the clitic heads that correspond to subject-verb agreement morphology. Thus, in accordance with much of the literature cited in the previous paragraph, it is the appearance of the agreement morphology which licenses the subject in Spanish. This situation in Spanish can be contrasted with a language like English, in which the subject is licensed by moving to a particular position: a contrast which, of course, has been connected in various ways to the null subject parameter (Rizzi 1982, a.m.o.).

A further difference between Spanish and a language such as English that is relevant here is the assignment of structural Case to the subject. Whereas English subjects are straightforwardly assigned nominative Case in Spec,TP with the relevant morphology reflected on pronominals, Etxepare & Gallego (2020) argue that nominative Case is actually not necessary to license subjects in Spanish. On this, they give the following condition.

- (79) *Subject Case Conjecture (SCC)* (Etxepare & Gallego 2020:49)
Nominative Case is not the only strategy to license subjects in Spanish.

In this analysis (Sect. 4.2.1), I have connected the availability of the third person morphology of object clitics to the presence of the KP, which corresponds to DOM with *a* on the nominal that

has been doubled. Here, we can see two pieces of evidence that subjects are licensed only through cliticization—i.e., subject-verb agreement morphology—and not through Structural Case.

First, as mentioned in Sect. 2.4, Spanish subject-verb agreement lacks any realizations for third person agreement, which is consistent with the view that third person is not featurally represented at all. 3SG agreement is thus taken to be a lack of agreement, while 3PL agreement with *-n* is the realization of a plural feature with no corresponding person value. Given the connection in this analysis between third person clitics, D⁰, and Structural Case, as in (69), we can take the lack of third person—or D-related—morphology in subject-verb agreement as a lack of Structural Case on Spanish subjects.

The second piece of evidence relatedly comes from the fact that there is no DOM with subjects at all in Spanish. While both accusative and dative clitic-doubled objects must co-occur with *a*, there is no such requirement for “nominative” subjects that undergo subject-verb agreement. In fact, to do so is impossible.¹² See the following.

- (80) a. Le= di el libro **(a)* mi esposo.
 him.DAT=give.1SG.PAST the book **(to)* my husband
 ‘I gave the book to my husband.’
 b. Dios nos= ama-Ø **(a)* nosotros.
 God us.ACC=love-3SG **(to)* we
 ‘God loves us.’
 c. Ya llega -mos (**a*) nosotros.
 already arrive-1PL (**to*) we
 ‘We already arrived.’

These facts are analytically reflected here through the lack of a KP in the subject-verb agreement series of clitic heads: compare (52) with (67). Further, they suggest an even stronger stance than Etxepare & Gallego’s SCC in (79): while they argue that nominative Structural Case may not be involved in Spanish subject licensing in certain configurations, the analysis here suggests that Structural Case does not play a role in Spanish subject licensing at all. As Etxepare & Gallego point out, this view is consistent with the empirical observation that so-called nominative subjects share the same form as unmarked/Caseless nominals that surface in, for instance, adjunct structures. On this, they say that “this can be a morphological accident, but perfectly fits with the absence of these features in the syntax” (Etxepare & Gallego 2020:50).

This fact on “nominative” being the unmarked form in Spanish can again be contrasted again with a nominative-Structural-Case licensing language such as English, in which the unmarked/caseless form (*them*) is clearly distinct from the nominative (*they*). Etxepare & Gallego

¹² One potential counterexample here is seen with impersonal *se* clauses, in which some speakers can obtain verbal agreement with a 3PL DOM-marked postverbal argument (Ormazabal & Romero 2024).

(iv) Se=censura-ron a los oponentes políticos. (Ormazabal & Romero 2024:451)
 SE=censor -3PL.PAST to the opponents political.PL
 ‘The political opponents were censored.’

Rather than analyzing the postverbal argument DP here as a DOM-marked subject, though, it seems more apt to claim that it is an object which can atypically undergo subject-verb agreement, given that such an argument can also be clitic-doubled with an accusative object clitic *los* (Ormazabal & Romero 2024:475). For a detailed account of environments in which such agreement with a thematic object is possible, see Storment (2025).

(2020:57) point out the high degree of variation that is able to be realized with “Surface Structure” phenomena such as Case (and licensing in general), which is a point that I would like to emphasize here.

While it has been assumed—e.g., by Chomsky (1995)—that there is an inherent link between nominative Structural Case, subject-verb agreement, and EPP movement, the picture painted here is one in which these phenomena can be teased apart from one another and may not all three be present in a given language variety. Thus, we should expect a high degree of variation as to which strategies a language variety may make use of to license subjects.

Specifically regarding variation within Romance, consider languages that make use of subject clitics (SCLs), including French (81) and Northern Italo-Romance varieties such as Veronese (82).

- (81) L' enfant *il*= parle. (Palasis 2015:126)
 the child SCL.3SG.M=speak.3SG
 ‘The child speaks.’

- (82) la 'letara *la*= 'riva do'maŋ. (Pescarini 2022:2)
 the letter SCL.3SG.F=arrive.3SG tomorrow
 ‘The letter arrives tomorrow.’

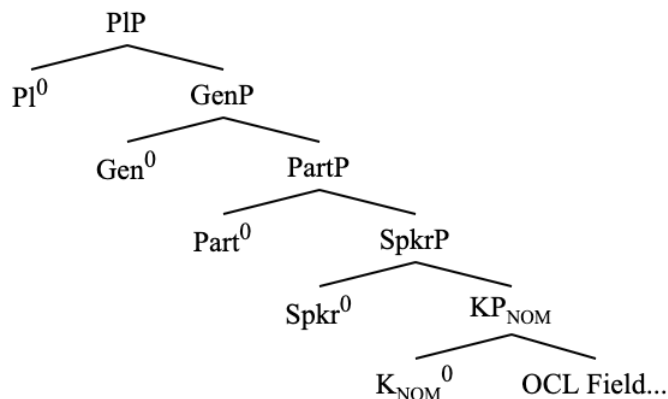
Empirically, SCLs are a distinct phenomenon from subject-verb agreement morphemes, and may occur with or without a rich paradigm of subject-verb agreement—as in several Northern Italo-Romance varieties and in French, respectively (Pescarini 2022).

Pescarini (2022) connects the presence of SCLs in Romance to the EPP: SCLs appear in certain Romance varieties to satisfy the EPP requirement in those languages when subject-verb agreement is not able to license the subjects on its own.

I would like to connect this reasoning to Structural Case. If Structural Case is—as the name suggests—a property of a specific structural configuration, such as being the complement of a KP or moving to a particular licensing position (e.g., Spec,TP), then the necessity in a given language of an argument to appear in a specific preverbal position in order to be licensed has clear connections to Case assignment. Additionally, Romance SCLs in both (81) and (82) involve third person *l*- forms, which is further reason to connect their distribution to Structural Case assigned in a configuration with a particular D head.

SCLs appear in Romance languages where Structural Case (and/or the EPP) play a role in the licensing of subjects, which not the case for Spanish. We can imagine in these languages a further series of clitic licensing heads, located above the object clitic field (in the case of a language like French) and endowed with a nominative Case head.

(83) Subject Case licensing field in SCL languages



In SCL Romance languages, then, nominative Case is licensed by External Merge + FC with the relevant clitic heads, just as subject-verb agreement and object clitic heads license the relevant features of Spanish arguments.

Thus, there is considerable crosslinguistic variation as to the mechanisms involved in licensing subjects. Furthermore, there is variation in how a particular realization of a given licensing mechanism may be realized across languages: e.g., nominative subject licensing in English clearly does not work this way at all. As we have seen here, the role that Structural Case plays in licensing subject arguments within Romance varies greatly, and can be considered independently of the role that subject-verb agreement morphology plays, which also varies crosslinguistically.

Crucially, though, the phenomena of subject-verb agreement morphology and argument clitics can be underlyingly explained in the same way: as functional heads that license properties of particular features of arguments. The crosslinguistic differences regarding the availability of subject cliticization and verbal agreement—as well as the formal and distributional differences between argument clitics and so-called “true” agreement morphemes—come down to the particular licensing properties of individual features within a language, how those features are realized within arguments, and where these functional licensing heads appear relative to other structures (i.e., whether or not they correspond to the verb’s amalgamation/linearization domain).

In what follows, I spend time discussing the types of variation that we expect to be realized in this Merge-based approach to clitics as functional licensing heads.

4.4 Accounting for linguistic variation

In accordance with the assumptions of the SMT that have been adopted throughout this paper, the computational framework of the narrow syntax is maximally simple. This assumption, of course, must inform the kinds of constraints that one places on the combinatoric properties of individual features: how they combine with one another via Merge. Merge, then, is a maximally simple operation that freely applies to any two elements. Under this view of *simplest Merge*, there are not even selectional features driving Merge (Chomsky et al. 2019:237-8).

In this view, adopting simplest Merge, constraining crosslinguistic variation becomes a massive enterprise. On the other side of the same coin, though, accounting for the massive amounts of crosslinguistic variation that do exist can be systematically derived without endless ad hoc stipulations on what is or is not “selected” from one language variety to the next. In other words, we should expect a high degree of licit variation in a system where Merge is not so constrained. In

this section, I show that this claim is founded, discussing cases of interspeaker, dialectal, and crosslinguistic variation in the realization of argument clitic and agreement morphemes and showing how they can be explained under a view of simplest Merge (Sect. 4.4.2), after first discussing why “overgeneration” is not a concern in this framework (Sect. 4.4.1).

4.4.1 Constraining variation

There is an obvious question of how anything ends up violating any well-formedness conditions in language if Merge applies freely. In other words, how do we have anything that is judged to be ungrammatical by native speakers? On this issue, Chomsky et al. (2019) have the following to say.

- (84) ‘Merge thus applies freely, generating expressions that receive whatever interpretation they are assigned by interfacing systems. Surface stimuli deriving from the objects constructed by I-language can have any degree of perceived “acceptability” or “deviance,” from perfect naturalness to complete unintelligibility. Since Chomsky 1955 it has been recognized that no independently given notion of “well-formedness” exists for natural language in the way it is stipulated for artificial symbolic systems (Chomsky & Lasnik 1993:508). Consequently, concerns about “overgeneration” in core syntax are unfounded; the only empirical criterion is that the grammar associate each syntactic object generated to a <SEM,PHON> pair in a way that corresponds to the knowledge of the native speaker. In fact, “overgeneration” must be permitted on purely empirical grounds, since “deviant” expressions are systematically used in all kinds of ways’ (Chomsky et al. 2019:238).

In any case, though, we have to contend with the fact that there are certain patterns within any given language that are completely unattested, while other patterns allow considerable variation. For instance, number mismatches in agreement and cliticization are rather ubiquitous, whereas person mismatches are not possible at all.

- (85) *Dios os_i = ama - $\emptyset$ a nosotros $_i$.
 God y’all.ACC= love -3SG to us
int: ‘God loves us.’

Ungrammatical examples such as this should be filtered out by the licensing requirements that first and second person pronominal expressions carry (see Sect. 4.2.2). In (85), while the clitic head for plural -s and participant *o*- are present, there is no speaker head *n*- to license the speaker feature of the 1PL pronominal. Thus, an example such as (85) fails to conform to the interpretive conditions of first and second person pronominal expressions as the speaker feature has not been licensed. Following this reasoning, many ungrammatical utterances can be filtered out by the licensing requirements of particular features.

It is worth mentioning that the licensing requirements of particular features for the goal of meeting certain interpretive conditions should ultimately be connected to some kind of deeper explanation, lest these kinds of stipulations be taken as ad hoc conjecture. For example, the particular interpretive conditions on first and second person exist because these features are indexical and their interpretation is highly sensitive to the properties of the discourse in which they appear, as has been noted in the relevant literature on the Person Licensing Condition (PLC) (e.g.,

Béjar & Rezac 2003; Baker 2008; Raynaud 2020). As I go on to show, no such conditions are imposed on plural features or gender features, the interpretive qualities of which are much more straightforward, and, as a result of this, number and gender mismatches are much more frequent.

As for why argument clitics and subject-verb agreement morphemes are realized in (mostly) fixed positions and a (mostly) fixed order (and why variation from these tendencies results in degradation of grammaticality), we should consider what the SMT has to say about I-language acquisition and formation. The computational system underlying language must be rich enough to be required, while also being simple enough to have evolved (Chomsky 2021:7). There is an evolutionary incentive, then, for a given I-language to not permit endless variation so that the language acquirer does not have to internalize an inconceivably large number of patterns.

What then rules out an ACC-DAT clitic cluster in most circumstances in Spanish, or what prevents subject-verb agreement from appearing in the position of an argument clitic despite the same technology producing both phenomena, is the fact that a sequence of functional heads should be acquired in a single, uniform manner in accordance with natural principles of computational efficiency. If significant variation is introduced into the order in which a given sequence of heads may be formed via Merge, then the task of the language user to acquire the syntactic structures in their language becomes exponentially more complicated.

For example, I have posited a sequence of maximally six functional heads for the object clitic field in Spanish: K_{DAT}^0 , $Spkr^0$, $Part^0$, K_{ACC}^0 , Gen^0 , and Pl^0 . Acquired in a single, uniform manner, the language user must only acquire a single pattern. If, however, a given language allows any ordering of these heads, then the language user must acquire up to $720(=6!)$ patterns. There thus exists a strong incentive for the computational system to be restrained in this way for the sake of evolvability and acquirability. This reasoning can be extended to a fixed $V^0-v^0-T^0$ order as well.

There is, however, no obvious reason to constrain this kind of variability across different I-languages. Different I-languages as distinct objects of acquisition should be expected to show significant variation in their combinatoric properties, which is indeed the case. For example, the DAT-ACC order for multiple object clitics is by no means fixed within Romance, and we can observe significant variation in the combinatoric properties of these clitic licensing heads across different varieties of Spanish. I turn to a discussion of these kinds of variation now.

4.4.2 Explaining variation

Under the view of freely-applying simplest Merge, we should expect a significant degree of variation in terms of licit structures that are formed by Merge across different I-languages. In the domain of clitics and subject-verb agreement morphemes, this expectation is certainly borne out.

As I have shown throughout this paper, there is significant intraspeaker, dialectal, and crosslinguistic variation within Spanish—and within Romance more generally—in terms of what features within a given argument clitic sequence may be realized, and to what extent. These variable phenomena include optional subject-verb agreement and optional realization of certain doubled argument clitics in certain dialects of Spanish (Sect. 2.1), optional mesoclisism (Sect. 2.2), constrained optional number feature realization in clitic clusters (Sect. 4.2), as well as the variable realization of SCLs across Romance language varieties (Sect. 4.3).

I have explained some of these phenomena—particularly mesoclisism and number realization in clitic clusters—as amalgamation effects, though there is a deeper question to be asked of why these effects are only seen with plural. This is an observation that we can connect to variable realization

of plural features more generally. Take, for instance, the examples of optional agreement in Sect. 2.1, the vast majority of which involve optional realization of the plural morpheme *-n*.

The high degree of variation in the realization of number here (see also fn. 12) is directly connected to the fact that no special licensing conditions exist for plural features in the way that they do for speaker/participant features. There is also no adjacency requirements between [Pl] and any other feature as there is, for example, with [Part] and [Spkr]. Variable realization in number is seen in a variety of other situations such as adjectival inflection (e.g., Storment 2026) and the “le-for-les” rule (Cuervo 1955; Ausín & Fernández-Rubiera 2017; Hoff & Schwenter 2019, a.o.).

- (86) Le= dice-Ø adiós a las garzas que pasa-n. (Ausín & Fernández-Rubiera 2017:104)
 3SG.DAT=say -3SG goodbye to the herons that pass -3PL
 ‘(S)he says goodbye to the herons that fly by.’

One can also observe variable realization in the realization of gender features. Sticking to the argument clitic domain, we can see this phenomenon with *leísmo* for direct object clitics, in which gender is not realized (Ordóñez & Roca 2018) on clitics that normally show gender agreement.

- (87) Le= vi. (Bleam 2000:1)
 3SG.ACC=see.1SG.PAST
 ‘I saw him/her.’

There is also *loísmo* and *laísmo*, in which gender features appear on indirect object clitics that normally lack them in Standard Spanish. See the following example of *laísmo*.

- (88) Cuando vi a Marta, la di un libro. (Ausín & Fernández-Rubiera 2017:116)
 when see.1SG.PAST to Marta, her.DAT give.1SG.PAST a book
 ‘When I saw Marta, I gave her a book.’

These variable realizations are highly sensitive to specific grammatical configurations as well as pragmatic context and register, along with other features (which I have not represented in this paper, but which should be assumed to be present in the syntax) such as animacy (Ausín & Fernández-Rubiera 2017). Furthermore, many of these variable phenomena are only possible in certain dialects of Spanish (i.e., there are many speakers who would not accept such examples).

Given simplest Merge, there is nothing that is predicted to go wrong in the narrow syntax to rule out these kinds of variable realizations in features for which no interpretive or formal licensing conditions exist. In other words, it should be surprising that these features such as number and gender sometimes fail to appear in contexts where they might be expected, and as well that they sometimes appear in contexts where they are not typically realized.

Within language varieties that allow them, these variable realizations are sensitive to grammatical structure, which suggest that the ability to not add a plural licensing head into a derivation via Merge is only possible in certain syntactic configurations. In other words, these realizations are only possible under certain conditions which must be acquired. Additionally, the fact that the variable realizations are sensitive to factors such as pragmatic context, register, and language variety further suggests that given <SEM,PHON> pairings are only licit in the contexts in which they are acquired by native language users.

Thus, variable <SEM,PHON> pairs generated by simplest Merge are accepted by language users to the degree that they can be assigned a licit interpretation at interfaces: see (84). Ultimately,

this process is constrained by factors related to the simplicity of acquisition, as well as interpretive conditions imposed on the realization of certain features. As I have shown, this simplest-Merge-driven approach can accommodate a relatively high degree of variation in the domain of argument cliticization while simultaneously accounting for the ways in which variation is constrained within specific language varieties. This reasoning can further explain crosslinguistic variation in the ways that given clitic features are realized and interact with one another, such as variable realizations in PCC effects in clitic clusters across Romance: e.g., in Romanian (Ciucivara 2009).

5 Conclusion

In this paper, I have supported a unified view of subject-verb agreement morphology and argument cliticization in which both phenomena are derived under a “base generation” analysis of cliticization (Sportiche 1996) using Spanish as the main linguistic object of study. I have shown that Spanish argument clitics and subject-verb agreement morphemes show a striking number of formal and distributional similarities that significantly complicate tests that have been put forth in the prior literature to help underlyingly distinguish the two phenomena, which has served as the empirical motivation to advocate for a unified analysis.

Placing these facts in the context of the SMT, I have further shown that Merge (along with third factor toolkit explanations) is sufficient as the only operation in the narrow syntax needed to account for both the underlying similarities and surface differences between argument clitics and subject-verb agreement. Moving away from Agree and incorporating a strong notion of the Principle of Decompositionality, it is possible to adequately account for various formal properties and interaction effects between multiple argument clitics and subject-verb agreement morphemes under a view of the relevant morphemes as functional heads that license particular features. In this way, I have accounted for the spurious-*se* rule, PCC effects, mesoclitisis, and several points of variation in clitic realization across Romance.

I have additionally connected the cliticization view of subject-verb agreement morphology to a long-standing literature on the licensing of subjects in Spanish. Most notably, I have connected this analysis to the proposal from Etxepare & Gallego (2020) that Spanish may actually lack nominative Structural Case for the licensing of subjects.

Lastly, I have connected this analysis and the tenets of the SMT more generally to the high degree of variation that is seen within Spanish and within Romance more generally regarding the realization and combinatoric properties of cliticization and subject-verb agreement, which I believe connects to a larger—and very open—question regarding the nature of syntactic variation and how it is acquired, represented, and constrained.

Moving forward, I believe that this approach to cliticization and agreement will be fruitful in explaining the behavior of non-argument clitics such as ethical datives, as well as other types of clitics not analyzed here that display unique properties of their own, such as reflexives (including impersonal *se*) and locative clitics in Romance. This kind of analysis also bears relevance to subject-verb agreement realizations in other language families, such as Bantu, whose subject-verb agreement morphemes strongly resemble clitics as well (Hartford 2008).

In conclusion, this Merge-based approach to subject-verb agreement and cliticization offers a number of explanatory and theoretical advantages to various aspects of the formal, distributional, and variational properties of these classes of morphemes in Spanish and Romance (and potentially beyond), all while significantly reducing the technology stipulated within the syntactic component of natural language grammar to only include Merge.

References

- Aissen, Judith & Rivas, Alberto. 1975. The proper formulation of the spurious-*se* rule in Spanish. In *Proceedings of the First Annual Meeting of the Berkeley Linguistics Society*, 1-15.
- Alexiadou, Artemis & Anagnostopoulou, Elena. 1998. Parametrizing Agr: Word Order, V-Movement and Epp-Checking. *Natural Language & Linguistic Theory* 16, 491-539. <https://doi.org/10.1023/A:1006090432389>
- Angelopoulos, Nikos. 2019. Reconstructing clitic doubling. *Glossa* 4(1), 118. <https://doi.org/10.5334/gjgl.748>
- Angelopoulos, Nikos & Sportiche, Dominique. 2021. Clitic dislocations and clitics in French and Greek: From interpretation to structure. *Natural Language & Linguistic Theory* 39, 959-1022. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s11049-020-09500-z>
- Armstrong, Grant & MacDonald, Jonathan. 2021. *Unraveling the complexity of SE*. Springer.
- Arregi, Karlos & Nevins, Andrew. 2018. Beware Occam's Syntactic Razor: Morphotactic analysis and Spanish mesoclis. *Linguistic Inquiry* 49(4), 625-683. https://doi.org/10.1162/ling_a_00286
- Ausín, Adolfo & Fernández-Rubiera, Francisco J. 2017. Láismo and "le-for-les": To agree or not to agree. In Perpiñán, Silvia & Heap, David & Moreno-Villamar, Itziri & Soto-Corominas, Adriana (eds.) *Romance languages and Linguistic Theory 11: Selected Papers from the 44th LSRL, London, Ontario*, 101-125. John Benjamins. <https://doi.org/10.1075/rllt.11.05aus>
- Baker, Mark. 1985. The mirror principle & morphosyntactic explanation. *Linguistic Inquiry* 16(3), 373-415.
- Baker, Mark. 1988. *Incorporation: A theory of grammatical function changing*. U. Chicago Press.
- Baker, Mark. 2008. *The Syntax of Agreement and Concord*. Cambridge University Press.
- Baker, Mark & Kramer, Ruth. 2018. Doubled clitics are pronouns: Amharic objects (and beyond). *Natural Language & Linguistic Theory* 36, 1035-1088. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s11049-018-9401-8>
- Banfi, Cristina S. 1999. *A minimalist approach to clitics and clitic doubling in Spanish*. Doctoral dissertation. University College London.
- Barbosa, Maria do Pilar Pereira. 1995. *Null Subjects*. Doctoral dissertation. MIT.
- Béjar, Susana. 2003. *Phi-syntax: A theory of agreement*. Doctoral dissertation. U. of Toronto.
- Béjar, Susana & Rezac, Milan. 2003. Person licensing and the derivation of PCC effects. In Pérez-Leroux, Ana Teresa & Roberge, Yves (eds.) *Romance linguistics: Theory & acquisition*, 49-62. John Benjamins.
- Belloro, Valeria A. 2007. *Spanish clitic doubling: A study of the syntax-pragmatics interface*. Doctoral dissertation. SUNY Buffalo.
- Benveniste, Emile. 1966. *Problèmes de linguistique générale*. Paris: Gallimard.
- Bernstein, Judy. 2008. Reformulating the Determiner Phrase analysis. *Language & Linguistics Compass* 2(6), 1246-1270. <https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1749-818x.2008.00091.x>
- Bernstein, Judy & Ordóñez, Francisco & Roca, Francesc. 2025a. Deixis and person in Ibero- and Gallo-Romance demonstratives. *Isogloss* 11(5), 1-24. <https://doi.org/10.5565/rev/isogloss.518>
- Bernstein, Judy & Ordóñez, Francisco & Roca, Francesc. 2025b. On the (non)isomorphism of Romance definite articles and clitic pronouns: A diachronic perspective. *Journal of Historical Syntax* 9(2), 1-24. <https://doi.org/10.18148/hs/2025.v9i2-10.220>
- Berwick, Robert & Chomsky, Noam. 2016. *Why Only Us*. Cambridge, MA: MIT Press.
- Bickford, J. Albert. 1985. Spanish clitic doubling and levels of grammatical relations. *Lingua* 65, 189-211.
- Bishop, Kelley & Michnowicz, Jim. 2010. Forms of address in Chilean Spanish. *Hispania* 93(3), 413-429.
- Bleam, Tonia. 2000. *Leísta Spanish and the syntax of clitic doubling*. Doctoral dissertation. UPenn.
- Blümel, Andreas. 2023. Deducing properties of subjects in NSLs and EPP-languages by FC and Minimal Search. Talk given at *Going Romance 37*, Radboud University, Nijmegen.
- Blümel, Andreas & Holler, Anke. 2022. DP, NP, or neither? Contours of an unresolved debate. *Glossa* 7(1). <https://doi.org/10.16995/glossa.8326>
- Bonet, Eulàlia. 1991. *Morphology after syntax: Pronominal clitics in Romance*. Doctoral dissertation. MIT.

- Brandi, Luciana, & Cordin, Patrizia. 1989. Two Italian Dialects and the Null Subject Parameter. In Jaeggli, Osvaldo & Safir, Kenneth (eds.), *The Null Subject Parameter: Studies in Natural Language and Linguistic Theory* 15, 111-142.
- Burukina, Irina. 2026. Non-finite “agreement” as cliticization. Talk given at *LSA Annual Meeting 2026*, New Orleans, Louisiana.
- Chomsky, Noam. 1995. *The minimalist program*. Cambridge, MA: MIT Press.
- Chomsky, Noam. 2000. Minimalist Inquiries: The Framework. In Martin, Roger & Michaels, David & Uriagereka, Juan (eds.) *Step by Step: Essays on minimalist syntax in honor of Howard Lasnik*, 89-153. Cambridge, MA: MIT Press.
- Chomsky, Noam. 2001. *Derivation by phase*. *Ken Hale: A Life in Linguistics*. 1–52. <https://doi.org/10.7551/mitpress/4056.003.0004>
- Chomsky, Noam. 2021. Minimalism: Where we are now, and where can we hope to go. *Gengo Kenkyu* 160, 1-41. http://doi.org/10.11435/gengo.160.0_1
- Chomsky, Noam. 2024. The Miracle Creed and SMT. In Greco, Matteo & Mocci, Davide (eds.) *A Cartesian Dream: A geometrical account of syntax in honor of Andrea Moro*, 17-40. Lingbuzz Press.
- Chomsky, Noam & Gallego, Ángel & Ott, Dennis. 2019. Generative Grammar and the Faculty of Language: Insights, Questions, and Challenges. *Catalan Journal of Linguistics Special Issue*, 229-261. <https://doi.org/10.5565/rev/catjl.288>
- Chomsky, Noam & Seely, T. Daniel & Berwick, Robert & Fong, Sandiway & Huybregts, M.A.C. & Kitahara, & Hitatsugu & McInnerney, Andrew & Sugimoto, Yushi. 2023. *Merge and the Strong Minimalist Thesis*. Cambridge University Press.
- Collins, Chris. 2017. Merge(X,Y) = {X,Y}. In Bauke, Leah & Blümel, Andreas & Groat, Erich (eds.) *Labels and Roots*, 47-68. De Gruyter Mouton.
- Collins, Chris. 2022. The complexity of trees, Universal Grammar and economy conditions. *Biolinguistics* 16, 1-13. <https://doi.org/10.5964/bioling.9573>
- Collins, Chris. 2024. *Principles of Argument Structure: A Merge-Based Approach*. MIT Press.
- Collins, Chris. 2025. Eliminating Agree. Manuscript. NYU.
- Collins, Chris & Kayne, Richard. 2023. Towards a theory of Morphology as Syntax. *Studies in Chinese Linguistics* 44(1), 1-32. <https://doi.org/10.2478/sci-2023-0001>
- Coon, Jessica & Keine, Stefan. 2021. Feature gluttony. *Linguistic Inquiry* 52(4), 655-710. https://doi.org/10.1162/ling_a_00386
- Cuervo, Rufino José. 1955. *Apuntaciones críticas sobre el lenguaje bogotano, con frecuente referencia al de los países de Hispano-América*. Bogotá: Instituto Caro y Cuervo.
- De Mello, George. 1992. “SE LOS” for “SE LO” In the spoken cultured Spanish of eleven cities. *Hispanic Journal* 13(1), 165-179.
- Deal, Amy Rose. 2024. Interaction, satisfaction, and the PCC. *Linguistic Inquiry* 55(1). 39-94.
- Estigarribia, Bruno. 2006. Why clitic doubling? A functional analysis for Rioplatense Spanish. Face, Timothy & Klee, Carol (eds.) *Proceedings of the 8th Hispanic Linguistics Symposium*, 123-126. Somerville, MA: Cascadilla Proceedings Project.
- Etxepare, Ricardo & Gallego, Ángel. 2020. Alternatives to Nominative Case in Spanish. *Linguistic Analysis* 42(3-4), 45-60.
- Fernández-Serrano, Irene. 2022. *Agreement and optionality: Evidence from Spanish variation*. Doctoral dissertation. Universitat Autònoma de Barcelona.
- Fernández-Soriano, Olga. 1993. *Los pronombres átonos*. Madrid, Taurus.
- Garza, Elizabeth. 2026. A computational analysis of long-distance [n]-displacement in Spanish. Manuscript. Stony Brook University.
- Garza, Elizabeth & Ordóñez, Francisco. 2026. Mesocclisis with infinitives in Spanish. Talk given at *Morphology as Syntax 4*, Queens College, New York.
- Gravely, Brian & Krapp-López, Carlos & Greeson, Daniel. 2023. It’s not you, it’s your probe: A reply to Béjar & Kanhemuyipour (2023). Manuscript. Emory University.

- Grishin, Peter. 2023. Omnivorous third person agreement in Algonquian. *Glossa* 8(1). <https://doi.org/10.16995/glossa.8874>
- Hardin, Karol Joy. 1993. Obligatory dative clitic doubling in Spanish. *Work Papers of the Summer Institute of Linguistics* 37(1), 151-183. <https://doi.org/10.31356/silwp.vol37.01>
- Harley, Heidi & Ritter, Elizabeth. 2002. Person and number in pronouns: A feature-geometric analysis. *Language* 78(3), 482–526. <https://doi.org/10.1353/lan.2002.0158>
- Harris, James & Halle, Morris. 2005. Unexpected plural inflections in Spanish: Reduplication and metathesis. *Linguistic Inquiry* 36, 195-222.
- Harris, James. 1994. The syntax-phonology mapping in Catalan and Spanish clitics. *MIT WPL* 21.
- Hartford, Carolyn. 2008. The Bantu-Romance connection in verb movement and verbal inflectional morphology. In De Cat, Cécile & Demuth, Katherine (eds.) *The Bantu-Romance Connection*, 111-130. John Benjamins.
- Hoff, Mark & Schwenter, Scott. 2019. Variable constraints on Spanish clitics: A cross-dialectal overview. In *The Routledge Handbook of Variationist Approaches to Spanish*, 513-534. <https://doi.org/10.4324/9780429200267-37>
- Höhn, Georg. 2014. Unagreement is an illusion. *Natural Language & Linguistic Theory* 34(2), 543-592. <https://doi-org.proxy.library.nyu.edu/10.1007/s11049-015-9311-y>
- Holmberg, Anders. 2010. Null subject parameters. In Biberauer, Theresa & Holmberg, Anders & Roberts, Ian & Sheehan, Michelle (eds.) *Parametric Variation: Null subjects in minimalist theory*, 88-124. <https://doi.org/10.1017/CBO9780511770784.003>
- Hull, Alexander. 1988. The first person plural form: Je Parlons. *The French Review* 62, 242-247.
- Jaeggli, Osvaldo. 1982. *Topics in Romance syntax*. Foris.
- Jambrović, Samuel. 2025. *The structure and interpretation of (pro)nominal expressions in Spanish*. Doctoral dissertation. University of Toronto.
- Kayne, Richard. 1975. *French syntax: The transformational cycle*. Cambridge, MA: MIT Press.
- Kayne, Richard. 1989. Null subjects and clitic climbing. In Jaeggli, Osvaldo & Safir, Kenneth (eds.) *The Null Subject Parameter*, 239-262. Kluwer.
- Kayne, Richard. 2000. *Parameters and Universals*. New York: Oxford University Press
- Kayne, Richard. 2005. *Movement and Silence*. Oxford University Press.
- Kayne, Richard. 2008. Comparative syntax and the lexicon. Manuscript. New York University.
- Kayne, Richard. 2010. Toward a syntactic reinterpretation of Harris & Halle (2005). In Bok-Bennema, Reineke & Kampers-Manhe, Brigitte & Hollebrandse, Bart (eds.) *RLLT 2008: Selected papers from 'Going Romance' Groningen 2008*, 145-170.
- Kayne, Richard. 2018. Toward an understanding of apparent suppletion in Romance pronominal possessives. *Probus* 30(2), 251-276. <https://doi.org/10.1515/probus-2018-0001>
- Ke, Alan Hezao. 2019. *The syntax, semantics and processing of agreement and binding grammatical illusions*. Doctoral dissertation. University of Michigan, Ann Arbor.
- Ke, Alan Hezao. 2023. Search downward: Minimal Search-based Agree. *Glossa* 8(1), 1-38. <https://doi.org/10.16995/glossa.6526>
- King, Ruth & Nadasdi, Terry & Butler, Gary. 2004. First-person plural in Prince Edward Island Acadian French: The fate of the vernacular variant je...ons. *Language Variation & Change* 16, 237-255. <http://doi.org/10.1017/S0954394504163035>
- Kramer, Ruth. 2014. Clitic doubling or object agreement: The view from Amharic. *Natural Language & Linguistic Theory* 32, 593-634. <http://doi.org/10.1007/s11049-014-9233-0>
- Krivochen, Diego Gabriel. 2023. The Search for Minimal Search: A graph-theoretic approach. *Biolinguistics* 17, e9793. <https://doi.org/10.5964/bioling.9793>
- Lasnik, Howard & Stowell, Tim. 1991. Weakest crossover. *Linguistic Inquiry* 22(4), 687-720.
- Longobardi, Giuseppe. 2008. Reference to individuals, person, and the variety of mapping parameters. In Høeg Müller, Henrik & Klinge, Alex (eds.) *Essays on Nominal Determination: From Morphology to Discourse Management*, 189-211. <https://doi.org/10.1075/slcs.99.11lon>

- Manzini, Maria Rita & Pescarini, Diego. 2022. The clitic string as a Pair Merge sequence. *Glossa* 7(1), 1-37. <https://doi.org/10.16995/glossa.6571>
- Martínez, José Antonio. 1999. La concordancia. In Bosque, Ignacio & Demonte, Violeta (eds.) *Gramática Descriptiva De La Lengua Española*, vol. 2, 2635-2694. Espasa.
- Matushansky, Ora. 2006. Head movement in linguistic theory. *Linguistic Inquiry* 37(1), 69–109. <http://doi.org/10.1162/002438906775321184>
- Mensching, Guido & Remberger, Eva. 2006. Probes: Lack of agreement in Romance. In Costa, João & Figueiredo Silva, Maria Cristina (eds.) *Studies on agreement*, 173-201. <https://doi.org/10.1075/la.86.09men>
- Muñoz-Pérez, Carlos. 2026. Stylistic applicatives: A lens into the nature of anticausative SE. *Glossa* 11(1), 1-44. <https://doi.org/10.16995/glossa.17369>
- Nevins, Andrew. 2007. The Representation of Third Person and Its Consequences for Person-Case Effects. *Natural Language & Linguistic Theory* 25, 273-313. doi:10.1007/s11049-006-9017-2
- Nevins, Andrew. 2011. Multiple Agree with clitics: Person complementarity vs. omnivorous number. *Natural Language & Linguistic Theory* 29, 939-971. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s11049-011-9150-4>
- Oltra-Massuet, Isabel & Arregi, Karlos. 2005. Stress-by-structure in Spanish. *Linguistic Inquiry* 36, 43-84.
- Ordóñez, Francisco. 1997. *Word order and clausal structure in Spanish and other Romance languages*. Doctoral dissertation. CUNY Graduate Center.
- Ordóñez, Francisco. 2002. Some Clitic Combinations in the Syntax of Romance. *Catalan Journal of Linguistics* 1, 201-224.
- Ordóñez, Francisco. 2012. Clitics in Spanish. In Bosque, Ignacio & Olarrea, Antxon & O'Rourke, Erin. *The Handbook of Hispanic Linguistics*. <https://doi.org/10.1002/9781118228098.ch21>
- Ordóñez, Francisco. 2024. Spanish causatives: Two specs for causees and two ways to resolve case. *Isogloss* 10(4-5), 1-22. <https://doi.org/10.5565/rev/isogloss.364>
- Ordóñez, Francisco & Roca, Francesc. 2018. Causativas y leísmo generalizado en dialectos del español. In *Relaciones sintácticas*, 531-546.
- Ordóñez, Francisco & Saab, Andrés. 2017. Sobre la distribución de los sujetos causados en dos dialectos del español. *Estudios lingüísticos e literarios* 58, 186-209.
- Ordóñez, Francisco & Treviño, Esthela. 1999. Left dislocated subjects and the pro-drop parameter: A case study of Spanish. *Lingua* 107, 39-68.
- Ormazabal, Javier y Romero, Juan. 2024. Deconstructing SE-Constructions: Number Agreement and Postsyntactic Variation. *Linguistic Inquiry* 55(3), 445-488. https://doi.org/10.1162/ling_a_00476
- Otero, Carlos P. 1986. Arbitrary subjects in finite clauses. In Bordelois, Ivonne & Contreras, Heles (eds.) *Generative Studies in Spanish Syntax*, 81-110. De Gruyter Mouton.
- Palasis, Katerina. 2015. Subject clitics and preverbal negation in European French: Variation, acquisition, diatopy and diachrony. *Lingua* 161, 125-143. <http://doi.org/10.1016/j.lingua.2014.11.012>
- Paparonas, Lefteris & Salzmann, Martin. 2024. First conjunct clitic doubling in Modern Greek: Evidence for Agree-based approaches to clitic doubling. *Natural Language & Linguistic Theory* 42, 323-382. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s11049-023-09585-2>
- Pato, Enrique & De Benito, Carlota. 2017. “Tráenolos para comérnolos” o la ‘transposición’ del clítico en español actual. *Philologica Jassysensia* 25, 121-136.
- Pescarini, Diego. 2007. Types of syncretism in the clitic systems of Romance. *Anuario del Seminario de Filología Vasca* 41(2), 285-300. <https://doi.org/10.1387/asju.3906>
- Pescarini, Diego. 2022. Expletive subject clitics in Northern Italo-Romance. *Languages* 7, 265. <https://doi.org/10.3390/languages7040265>
- Pollock, Jean-Yves. 1989. Verb movement, universal grammar and the structure of IP. *Linguistic Inquiry* 20(3), 365-425.
- Pollock, Jean-Yves. 1997. Notes on clause structure. In Haegeman, Liliane (ed.) *Elements of Grammar*, 237-280. Springer. https://doi.org/10.1007/978-94-011-5420-8_6
- Preminger, Omer. 2009. Breaking Agreements: Distinguishing agreement and clitic doubling by their failures. *Linguistic Inquiry* 40(4), 619-666.

- Preminger, Omer. 2014. *Agreement and its failures*. Cambridge, MA: MIT Press.
- Raynaud, Louise. 2020. *The features of binding and person licensing*. Doctoral dissertation. Georg-August Universität Göttingen.
- Rivas, Alberto. 1977. *A theory of clitics*. Doctoral dissertation. MIT.
- Rivera-Castillo, Yolanda. 1992. Enclitic pronouns in Caribbean Spanish. In *Proceedings of the 18th Annual Meeting of the Berkeley Linguistics Society*, 424-434.
- Rivera-Castillo, Yolanda. 1997. Proclitic groups and word order in Caribbean Spanish. In Black, James & Motapanyane, Virginia (eds.) *Clitics, Pronouns and Movement*, 237-273. John Benjamins.
- Rizzi, Luigi. 1982. *Issues in Italian syntax*. De Gruyter Mouton. <https://doi.org/10.1515/9783110883718>.
- Roberts, Ian. 2010. *Agreement and head movement*. Cambridge, MA: MIT Press
- Roberts, Ian. 2024. Form Copy, Agree and clitics. *Probus* 36(1), 17-29. <https://doi.org/10.1515/probus-2024-2003>
- Rodríguez-Mondoñedo, Miguel. 2008. Spanish existentials and other accusative constructions. *Minimalist Essays*. <https://doi.org/10.1075/la.91.20rod>
- Saab, Andrés. 2006. Accusative case, subject agreement: the Latin American Spanish existential construction with “haber”. Talk given at the *V Encontro Nacional sobre Língua Falada e Escrita/II Workshop Romania Nova*, Universidade Federal de Alagoas, Maceió, Brazil.
- Saab, Andrés. 2013. Anticoncordancia y sincretismo en Español. Unagreement and syncretism in Spanish. *Linguística* 29(2), 191–229.
- Saura, José Antonio. 2010. Peculiaridades sintácticas del castellano hablado en el valle de Benasque. In Castañer, R.M. & Lagüéns, V. (eds.), *De moneda nunca usada: Estudios dedicados a José M.a Enguita Utrilla*, 573-583.
- Shlonsky, Ur. 2023. Rescaffolding the bundle in Afroasiatic inflection: Tamazight and Hebrew. *Journal of Afroasiatic Languages & Linguistics* 15(1), 67-126. <https://doi.org/10.1163/18776930-01501002>.
- Sportiche, Dominique. 1996. *Clitic constructions*. Dordrecht: Springer.
- Storment, John David. 2025. *Projecting (your) voice: A theory of inversion and defective circumvention*. Doctoral dissertation. Stony Brook University.
- Storment, John David. 2026. Two is better than one: Subject DPs in Spanish third person plural arbitrary sentences. *Borealis: An International Journal of Hispanic Linguistics* 15(1).
- Suñer, Margarita. 1988. The role of agreement in clitic-doubled constructions. *Natural Language & Linguistic Theory* 6(3), 391-434.
- Taraldsen, Knut T. 1992. Agreement as pronoun incorporation. Paper presented at 1992 GLOW Colloquium.
- Taraldsen, Knut T. 1993. Subject/verb-agreement and word order in Celtic and Romance. In *Proceedings of NELS 23* 2, 495-504.
- Terzi, Arhonto. 1996. Clitic climbing from finite clauses and long head movement. *Catalan Working Papers in Linguistics* 3(2), 97-122.
- Terzi, Arhonto. 1999. Clitic combinations, their hosts and their ordering. *Natural Language & Linguistic Theory* 17(1), 85-121.
- Travis, Lisa. 1984. *Parameters and effects of word order variation*. Doctoral dissertation. MIT.
- Uriagereka, Juan. 1995. Aspects of the syntax of clitic placement in Western Romance. *Linguistic Inquiry* 26(1), 79-123.
- Van Urk, Coppe. 2015. *A uniform syntax for phrasal movement: A case study of Dinka Bor*. Doctoral dissertation. MIT.
- Villa-García, Julio. 2009. To agree or not to agree: Beyond quintessentially syntactic agreement in Spanish. In Colina, Sonia & Olarrea, Antxon & Carvalhno, Anna Maria (eds.) *Selected Papers from the 39th LSRL*, 249-266. John Benjamins.
- Wolfsgruber, Anne. 2021. Null-subjects and *se* revisited: What medieval Romance varieties reveal. In Armstrong, Grant & MacDonald, Jonatha (eds.) *Unraveling the complexity of SE*, 57-86. Springer.
- Yuan, Michelle. 2021. Diagnosing object agreement vs. clitic doubling: An Inuit case study. *Linguistic Inquiry* 52(1), 153-179. https://doi.org/10.1162/ling_a_00366
- Zwicky, Arnold & Pullum, Geoffrey. 1983. Cliticization vs. inflection: English n't. *Language* 59, 502-513.